3
Getting to Know Your Design Environment

In the previous chapter, you discovered the basic concepts of the UX process, which is without a doubt an essential part of any design project. As you work, it's best to keep all research results, analysis data, and other attributes nearby so you can always check if you're on your planned design path. Remember that the usability and clarity of your final user interface will directly depend on the quality of your UX work.

However, creating a user interface is also a tricky and time-consuming part of design work. You might have done some excellent research and collected enough relevant data, but your actual design work may not always be smooth and easy. In real life, anything can happen – maybe the chosen style will not be approved by the customer, or maybe your team decides to add a tablet version of your product. This book cannot anticipate all the challenges a designer might face, but you will definitely learn how to make your user interface work faster and more efficiently.

One of the key components of optimizing your workflow is knowing as much as possible about the capabilities of your design tool so you can get the most out of it. What basic and advanced features can it provide? Where can I find all the possible operations with elements? How to organize all layers and assets and get quick access to them? This and more is what you'll learn about using Figma in this chapter.

In this chapter, we are going to cover the following main topics:

- Starting a new project from scratch
- Overviewing the tools in the toolbar of Figma
- Learning the functionality of the left panel in Figma
- Exploring the right panel in Figma

Starting a new design project

In this chapter, you will temporarily step away from analysis and research work in FigJam files and instead discover Figma's essential tools and functions. You will find a lot of material to learn, and it's completely normal to feel overwhelmed by all this new information. But the good thing about this chapter is that you can refer to it from time to time when you're unsure of any of the basics of Figma. So don't worry about memorizing all the concepts of each function; you will see how everything works later on in the book, and each tool and feature will be explained in a more practical way.

Design files

You already know that Figma has two types of files – FigJam and design. You've learned about FigJam files in detail in the previous chapter. This time you will go back to the file selection and make another choice, namely to create a new design file.

To create a new blank design file, you have to open the welcome screen and click on **New design file** right on the top.

If you still have FigJam open with the previously created files, to go to the welcome screen, we just need to click on the Figma logo in the upper left corner and select **Back to Files** from the drop-down menu. Then, just proceed as previously described. However, if you are using the Figma desktop app, you can skip returning to the welcome screen and immediately press the + button to the right of the current file tab. Figma will prompt you to open a new project page where you can choose the type of new file – FigJam or design. You can also hit *Command* + *T* (macOS) or *Ctrl* + *T* (Windows) to quickly open a new tab, like in your browser, and you will be given a choice for your desired file type:

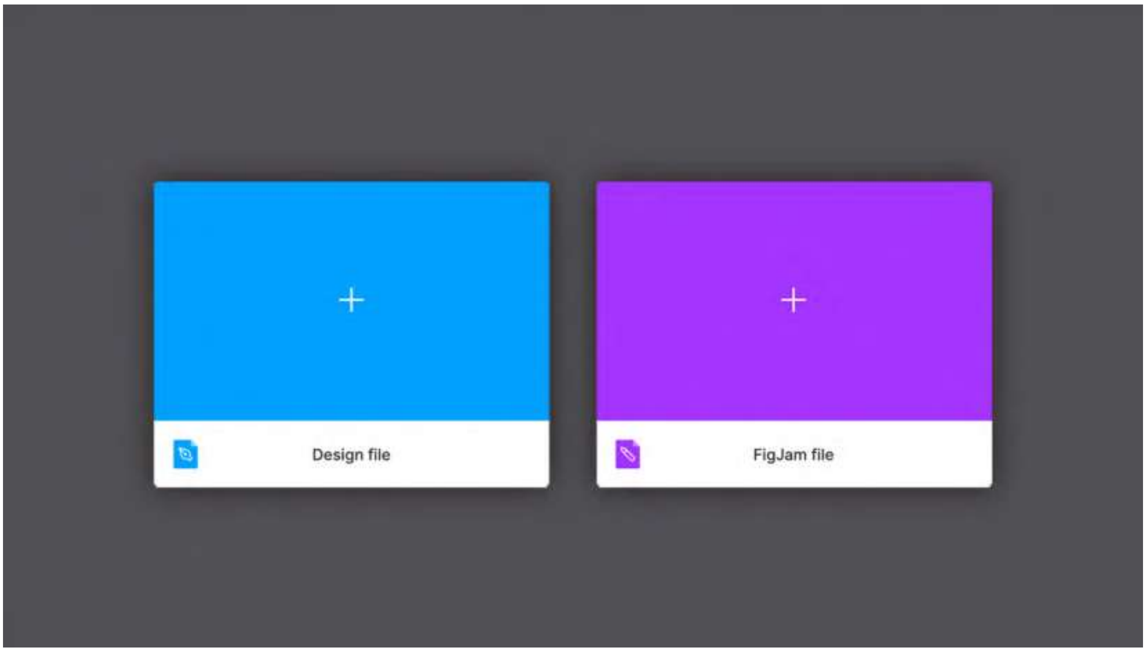

Figure 3.1 – A new file from the tab menu

Once you open a new design file, you can finally see Figma as it is, which is significantly different from what you had earlier with FigJam. It is a much more complex yet powerful working area that will allow you to create truly stunning masterpieces.

> **Note**
> Design and FigJam files can be easily recognized in the **Drafts** and **Recent** folders by their different colors and icons.

Frames and groups

When you first launch a design file, you see an empty gray space in front of you, framed by panels on either side and a toolbar at the top. At first glance, so many areas of different functionalities may seem complicated and almost intimidating. It is normal to feel that way because it is not a simple canvas but a place where you will create the entire interface of your project. Don't worry, you will explore all the sets of tools in Figma step by step. For now, the only thing you can interact with in an empty file is the top toolbar, which will be your starting point.

To start using Figma to its fullest, you need to create an artboard. You may be familiar with this concept from other design tools. However, Figma does not have standard artboards but rather something similar yet much more powerful – frames. While they share basic traits with artboards, frames differ in functionality. They can be nested, and also have auto layout, layout grids, and all prototyping functions set. You will learn more about this later, but for now, let's stop here.

What is a frame? In fact, it is a container. Your design must contain something, and it is frames that provide this opportunity. You can use custom-sized frames or choose practical presets for the most common standards, such as mobile devices, tablets, and desktop resolutions. So, it all starts with a single frame:

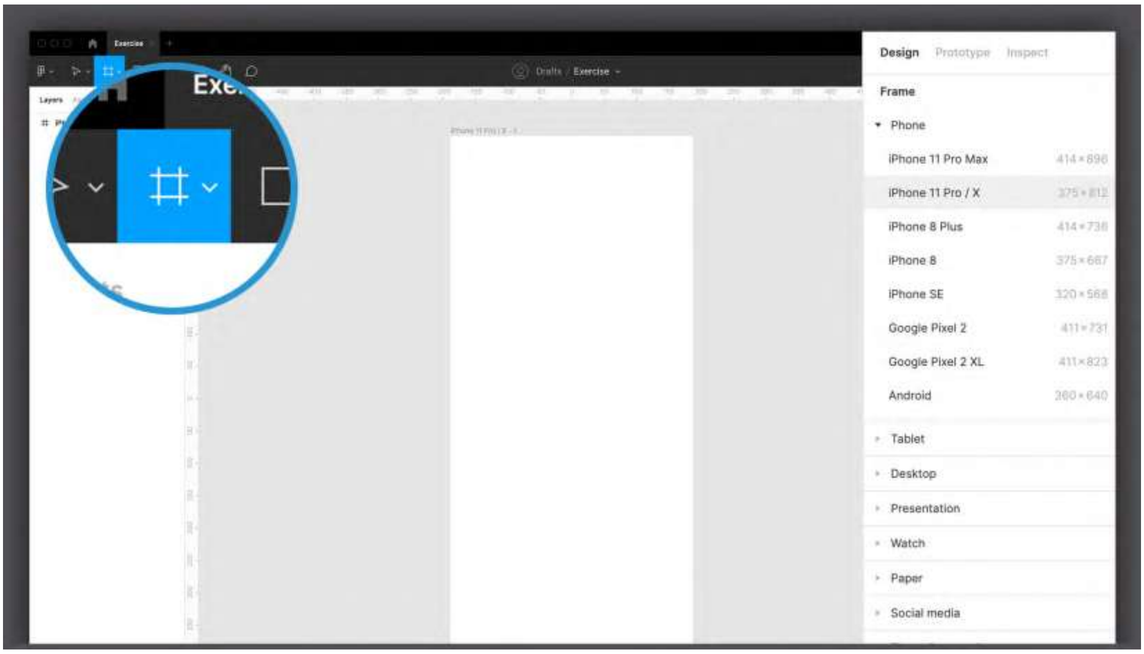

Figure 3.2 – The Frame tool's presets

To create a frame, you can use the **Frame** tool from the top toolbar (using the *F* or *A* shortcuts) and proceed in three different ways:

- Click any blank area on your workspace to create a default 100 x 100 frame.
- Click and drag with your cursor to create a custom-sized frame.
- Click on any preset size on the right panel to automatically create a frame of the appropriate size.

As you can imagine, the third option is most useful for immediately starting your design without having to search the internet for screen sizes of various devices. For example, clicking **Phone | iPhone 11 Pro / X** will immediately create a 375 x 812 frame. You can add more than one frame in your workspace, and no matter how many there are in your file, it is unlikely to slow down Figma.

But frames are not just artboards. They can act as containers as well, letting you nest as many elements or any other frame as you like. To quickly create a frame around one or more objects, simply select whatever you want to put together and press *Alt* + *Command* + *G* (macOS) or *Shift* + *Ctrl* + *G* (Windows). However, there is an alternative way to combine objects, and this method is called groups. Understanding the difference between frames and groups can be very confusing, as they share some basic functions, and you may think they are interchangeable, but this is mostly untrue. You will likely be using frames more often, since they offer a bunch of extra features, but there may be situations where you don't really need their advanced capabilities. Instead, you will be satisfied with something simpler, such as a group, that just combines several objects into one layer without flattening them and allowing you to maintain a fixed relationship between inner elements when scaling. If you want to create a group of objects, we just press *Command* + *G* (macOS) or *Ctrl* + *G* (Windows) after selecting the desired elements on the canvas. We can ungroup at any time by pressing *Shift* + *Command* + *G* (macOS) or *Shift* + *Ctrl* + *G* (Windows).

To visually understand frames and groups, combine two shapes into one frame and do the same with a group, and then try resizing the two containers. In the group, the shapes will be resized accordingly, while in the frame, what is scaled is only the frame itself, while the shapes retain their original size and position. Over time, as you progress through the chapters, you will fully understand the potential of frames, one of Figma's exclusive features, and this will lead you to have a clearer view of concepts that may now seem very complex.

Interface overview

Now that you've added the first frame on a gray backdrop, you may have noticed that the interface now provides you with a lot of new functions to explore. Now, it may seem more similar to many other design tools you may have used. However, compared to Adobe Photoshop, for example, Figma may seem like a tool that offers a rather limited number of features, and this may undermine your belief that Figma is still the best choice.

Of course, as mentioned earlier, it is also possible to create interfaces using Photoshop, but you will inevitably run into limitations, such as poor smoothness with numerous artboards and, above all, a lack of tools dedicated to prototyping. If you, for example, want to apply a watercolor effect to an image in your design, Figma will not be suitable for such purposes. However, it's important to emphasize that Figma has the essentials, and in most cases, that's pretty much all you need to create a complete interface. As a flexible collaboration tool, Figma can easily convert anything you create in it into web or mobile app development code, which is the point:

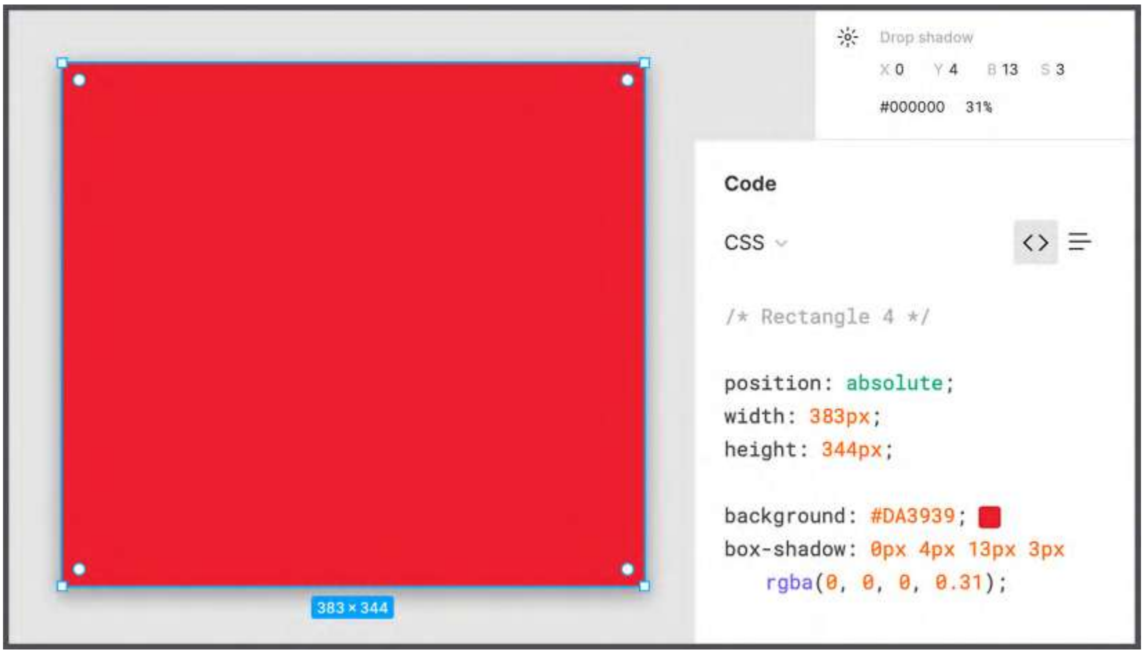

Figure 3.3 – Figma effects versus CSS effects

For example, if Figma allows you to apply a blur effect to an image, it's only because that effect can be applied in the same way with a CSS rule. However, there is no filter that can be applied with the code to apply the watercolor effect. This way, Figma guarantees that everything you design can actually be reproduced in code without much difficulty. Does this mean you can never apply a watercolor filter? Not at all. Without any problem, you can directly import an image that has been previously filtered into Figma. Adobe Photoshop, as well as Adobe Illustrator, are tools that can be perfectly combined with Figma to get more impressive results. However, using Figma as our main tool saves you from mistakes in design that can lead to problems in product development. As a result, you don't need to have any coding skills or worry about any technical constraints to create reliable layouts.

In addition, to make the experience even more user-friendly, Figma makes the most of a context-sensitive interface. This means that you will never see, for example, a left-align text icon unless you have selected text that can be aligned at that point. It is a methodology that more and more software has implemented in recent years, providing the user with the right tools and functions at the right time. Of course, for those of us new to this kind of UX, it can be difficult to find what they expect, but it really is only a matter of hours until you can no longer live without it:

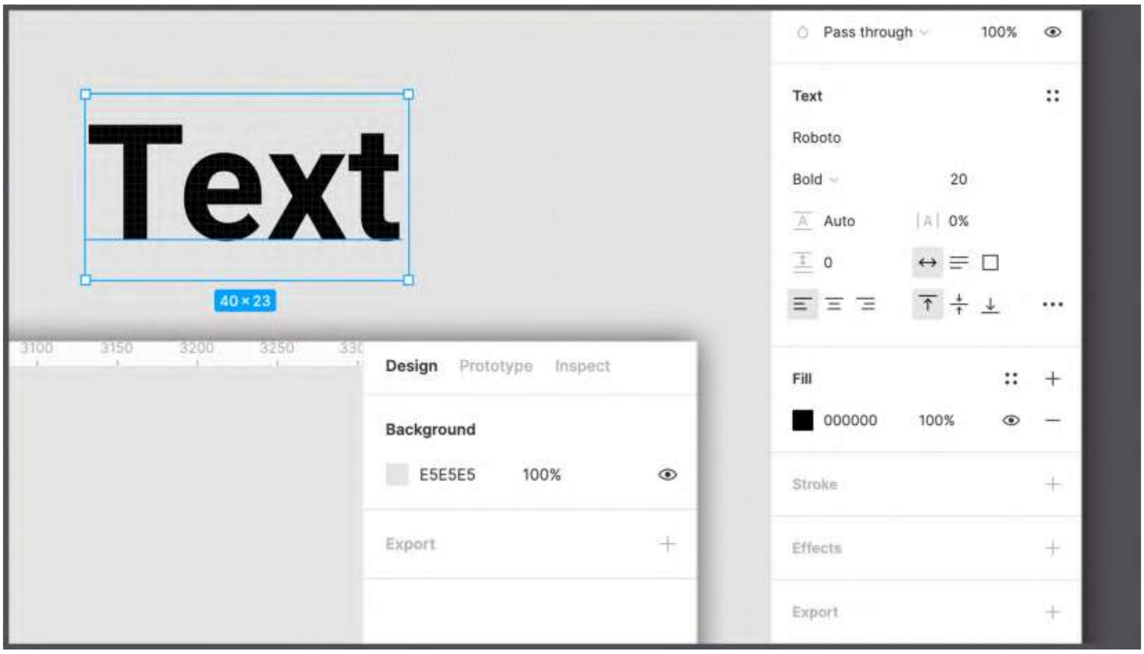

Figure 3.4 – An example of context-sensitive options

So, if you can't find a specific feature, it probably isn't available to you at the moment. In such cases, you should check whether you missed any steps or selected the wrong element. Everything becomes extremely simple and clear, and errors are minimized as much as possible.

Now, let's get down to exploring the interface piece by piece to get an idea of the tools and functions that Figma provides.

Exploring the toolbar

You'll start by exploring the top toolbar – this is where you'll find all of Figma's basic tools and settings. For the most commonly used basic tools, try to use right from the beginning as many shortcuts as possible because it will greatly improve your workflow.

Main tools

Figma divides its core tools into several sections, all of which you can see in the top bar. You will get an overview of all the sections in order, from left to right, and start by exploring the main set of features.

A – menu

The Figma logo in the upper left corner hides a significant drop-down menu that opens when you click on it:

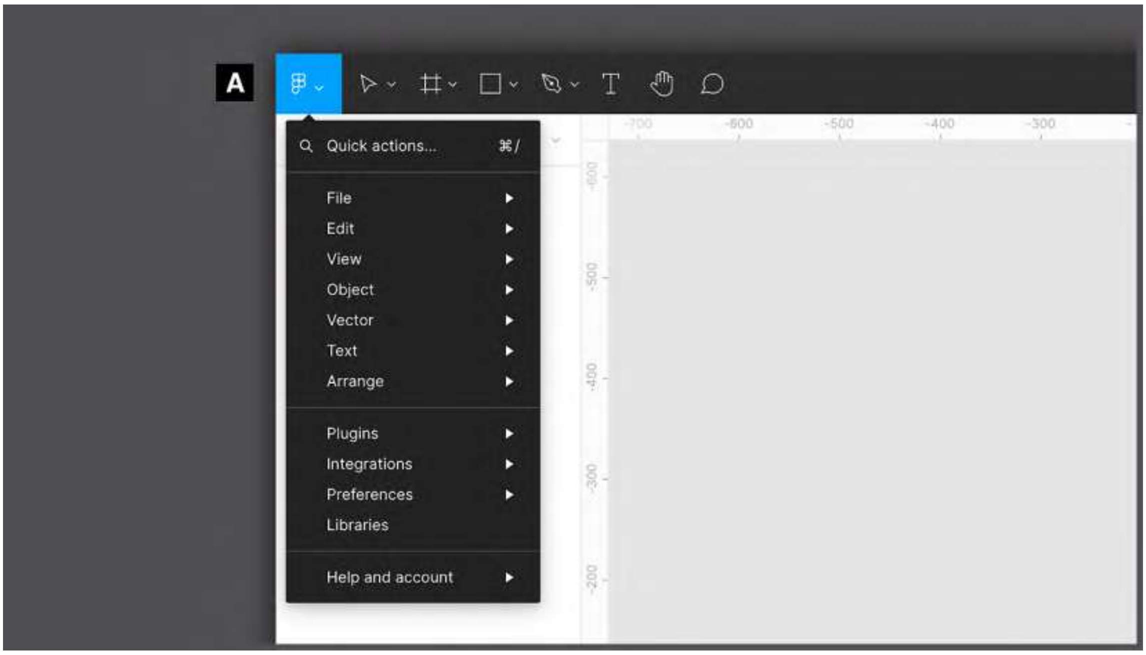

Figure 3.5 – Figma's main menu

This is the real main control center where you can find import, export, select, display, and many other functions. However, most of these features can be accessed in other ways. For example, anything on the **Text** menu is usually displayed in the context-sensitive panel (on the right) when any text is selected. It is not necessary to open each of the points contained here now, but you will try them in practice from time to time in the corresponding activities.

B – Move

This is the main tool that you will undoubtedly use the most. You can use it to select, move, resize, and rotate any element on the screen, including frames. By clicking and dragging, you can draw an area that will include and select all items inside it. The **Move** tool is quickly accessible with the *V* key on your keyboard, but you'll notice that Figma itself will automatically return you to this tool when you're done with any other tool:

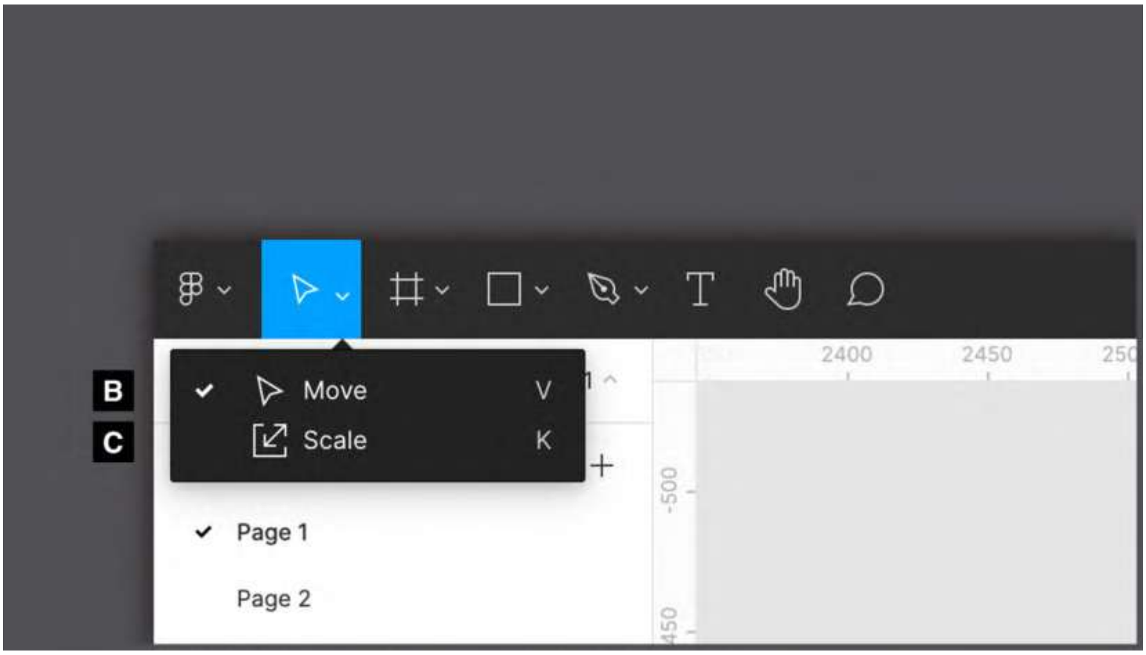

Figure 3.6 – The Move and Scale tools

C – Scale

Like the **Move** tool, the **Scale** tool (to quickly switch to this function, use the *K* shortcut) is used to resize any element in your working area. But the Scale tool works differently – it resizes any object in proportion to its original dimensions or the frame in which it is nested. To understand this better, type some text by pressing the *T* key, and then select and enlarge it with the Move tool. You can see that only the textbox will be larger and not the text itself. Instead, if you use the Scale tool, the font-size property will resize to fit the textbox.

D – Frame

As you know, with the **Frame** tool you can create a container by choosing from the available presets or by drawing a custom rectangle. Since this is one of Figma's core tools, you will be using it very often. You already have an understanding of frames in Figma, but you still have a lot more to learn about them, which you will do later in this book. For now, remember the useful keyboard shortcut for quickly adding a frame onto your canvas; there are two options – the *F* and *A* keys. Regardless of which one you choose, the result will be the same:

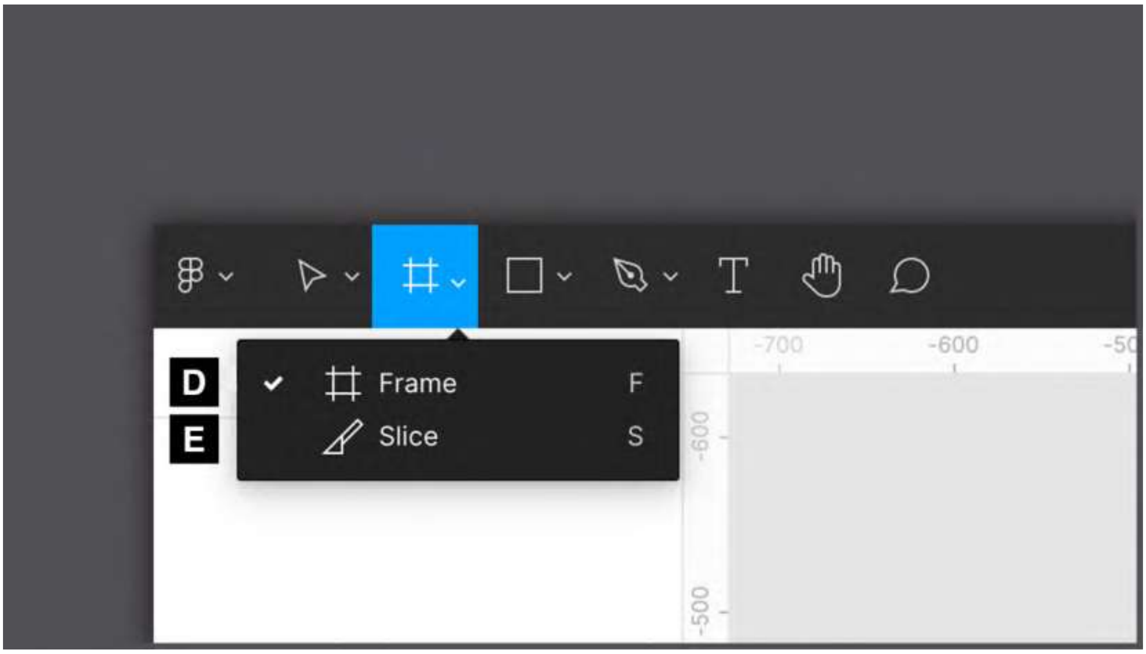

Figure 3.7 – The Frame and Slice tools

E – Slice

This is perhaps the least used of all tools, except in very special cases. The **Slice** tool allows you to select any areas in your workspace and export them with everything they visually contain. This tool comes from some old website design methods, so don't give it too much of your attention.

F, G, H, I, J, and K – shapes

This is a set of tools useful for creating all kinds of shapes, from simple lines to star shapes. Each of them has its own specific editing properties. For example, a line can become an arrow by changing the appropriate option in the context-sensitive right panel. Also, you should keep in mind that all shapes created this way are vectors, so you can easily modify them manually any way you want. You will explore shapes in detail in the next chapter:

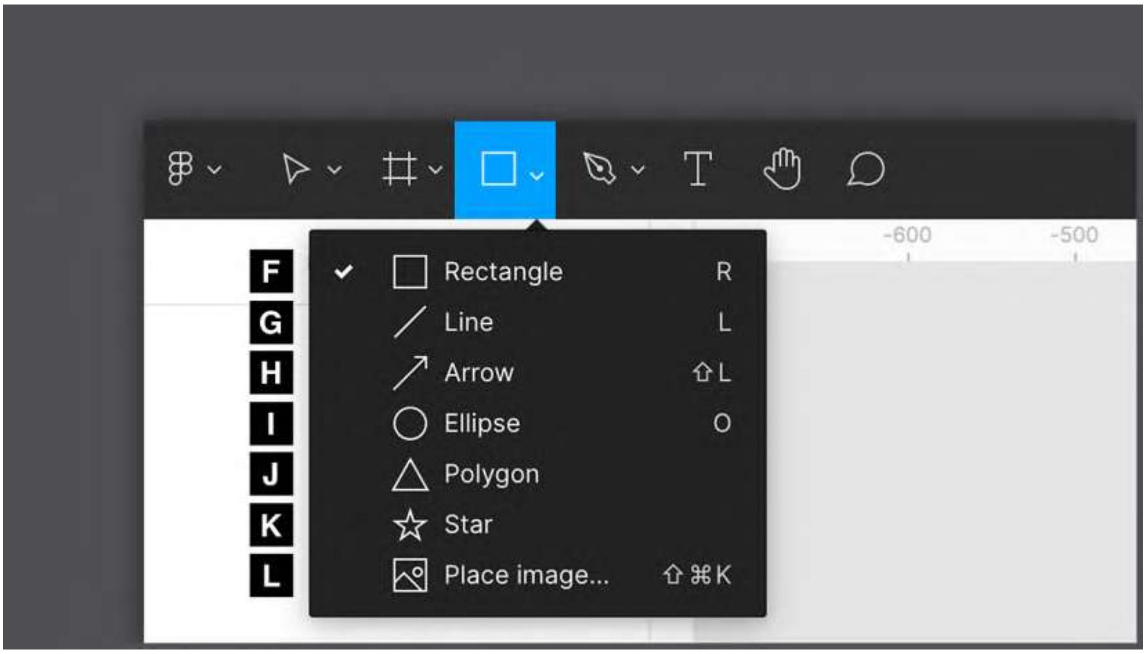

Figure 3.8 – The shape tools

L – Place image...

If you need to quickly add an image to your workspace, click the **Place Image…** tool and a dialog box will appear, where you can select an image to import from your computer. Alternatively, you can directly drag and drop an image from a folder on your computer to your workspace.

M – Pen

This one is as easy as it is powerful. With the **Pen** tool, you can draw any shape using so-called Bézier curves, from a simple line to any abstract element. And all this will be strictly in the vector. While a traditional raster image is composed of a grid of pixels, a vector creates shapes using primitives and mathematical calculations. This allows you to draw simple or complex illustrations that can be scaled to any size without loss of resolution. The *P* keyboard shortcut for the **Pen** tool is undoubtedly worth remembering:

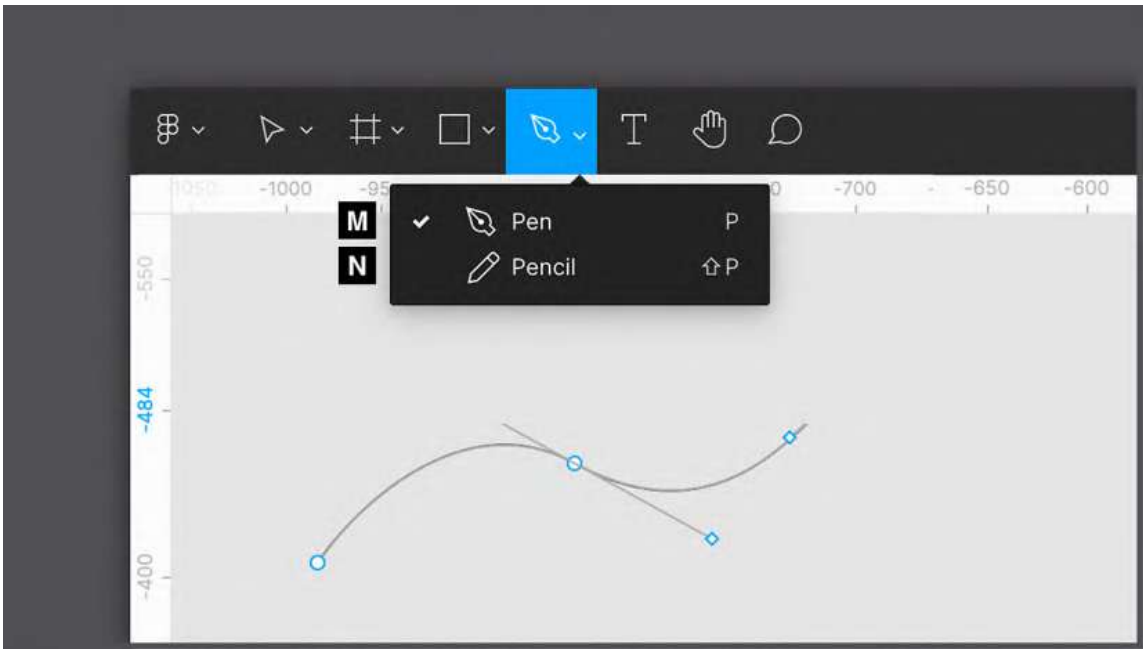

Figure 3.9 – The Pen tool with a Bézier curve example

N – Pencil

This is a vector tool like the **Pen** tool, but it doesn't have a curve system for drawing shapes. The **Pencil** tool is actually for freehand drawing but with the advantage that lines and curves are automatically enhanced and softened after you stop pressing the mouse button to end drawing. This can be useful, especially if you want to use Figma as a digital whiteboard or take quick freehand notes.

O – Text

The **Text** tool does exactly what you'd expect, allowing you to add text to your design. A shortcut for inserting any text is the *T* key on your keyboard, which you should definitely keep in mind. What's important to note about the **Text** tool is that there are two different methods for entering text. When you click anywhere on the canvas, the variable-width text is inserted into an external box that is sized based on the amount of text it contains. If you click and drag instead of a short click you will have a fixed-width textbox, and the entered text will not extend beyond the fixed space:

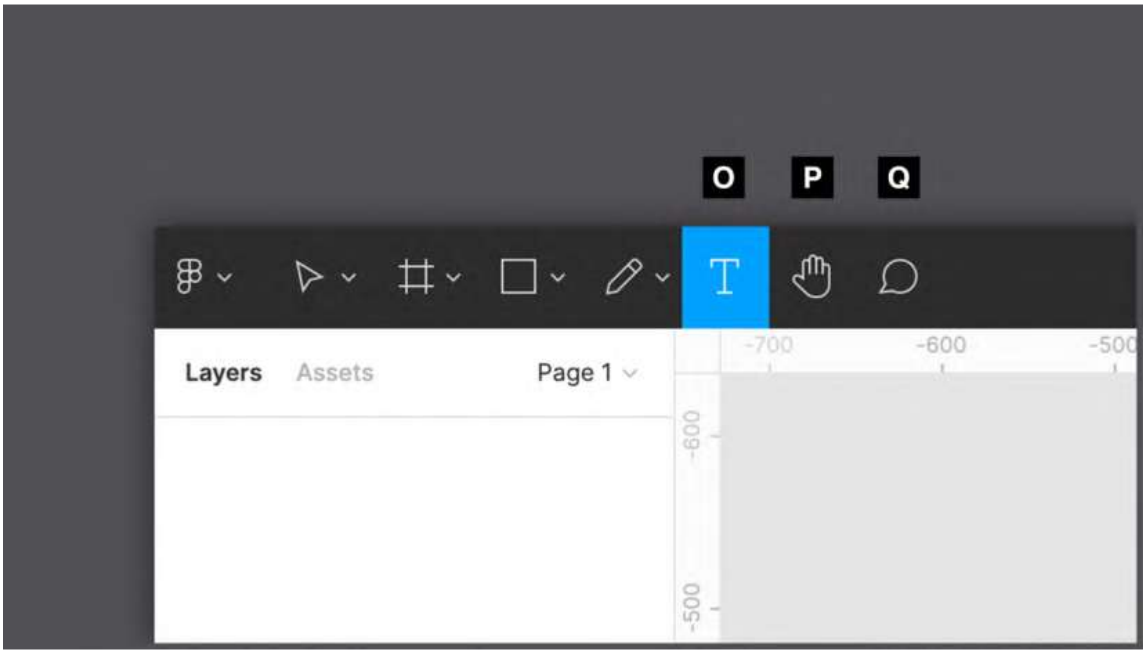

Figure 3.10 – The Text, Hand, and Comment tools

P – Hand

This tool allows you pan around the workspace using your mouse or trackpad, preventing accidental selection, repositioning, or any other impact on objects on the canvas. To activate the **Hand** tool, you can select it from the toolbar, but there is an easier and faster way to switch to it. To do this, you can press and hold the *spacebar* on your keyboard. This is a much more practical method that will definitely save you time. Imagine that you are currently using the **Move** tool, but from time to time you need to move around the board without affecting objects on the screen. In this case, you can simply hold down the *spacebar* to temporarily switch to the **Hand** tool. As soon as you release the key, you will automatically return to the **Move** tool. Also, if you are working on a trackpad, just swiping on it with two fingers will allow you to pan over your canvas.

Q – Comment

You should already know this one from working with FigJam. The **Comment** tool, which can be recalled with the *C* key, lets you click anywhere on the workspace and leave a text comment. All other users who have access to this project will receive a notification and therefore read what you have written at any time. All comments in the currently open file are visible only when the **Comment** tool is activated.

Settings and more

Now that you are familiar with all the basic tools, let's move on to looking at the rest of the functions located on the toolbar.

R – project title

"`Untitled`" is not the best name for a good organization of work, is it? To rename a file, just click on the current heading and enter a more appropriate and descriptive one. By clicking the drop-down arrow to the right of the title, you can access a number of additional actions, such as duplicating and deleting a file, or changing the path, which allows you to convert the file from a draft to a team project. Here you will also find version control – that is, the ability to access all saved files created in the current project and, if necessary, restore the old version. This feature saves up to 30 days of history when using the free starter plan, while there is no limit for the paid ones:

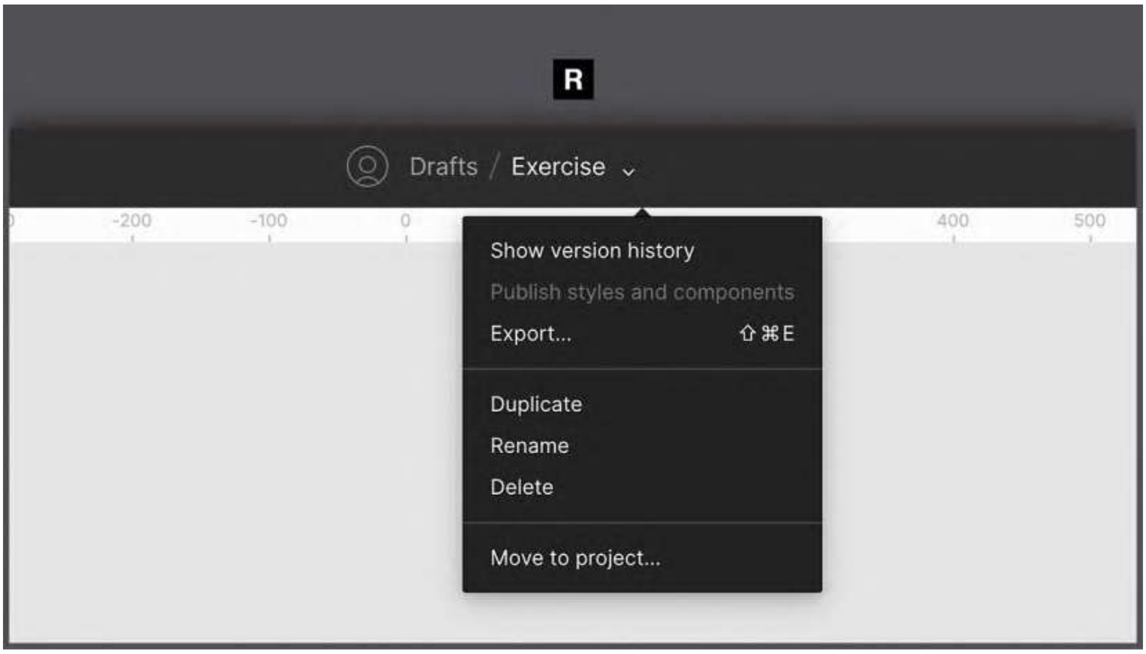

Figure 3.11 – A project's settings

S – active users

Here you will always have a real-time overview of the online users who are currently in this file. If you click the avatar of another active user, you activate observer mode for yourself, in which you can no longer independently move around the workspace, but you will see exactly what the selected user sees and does:

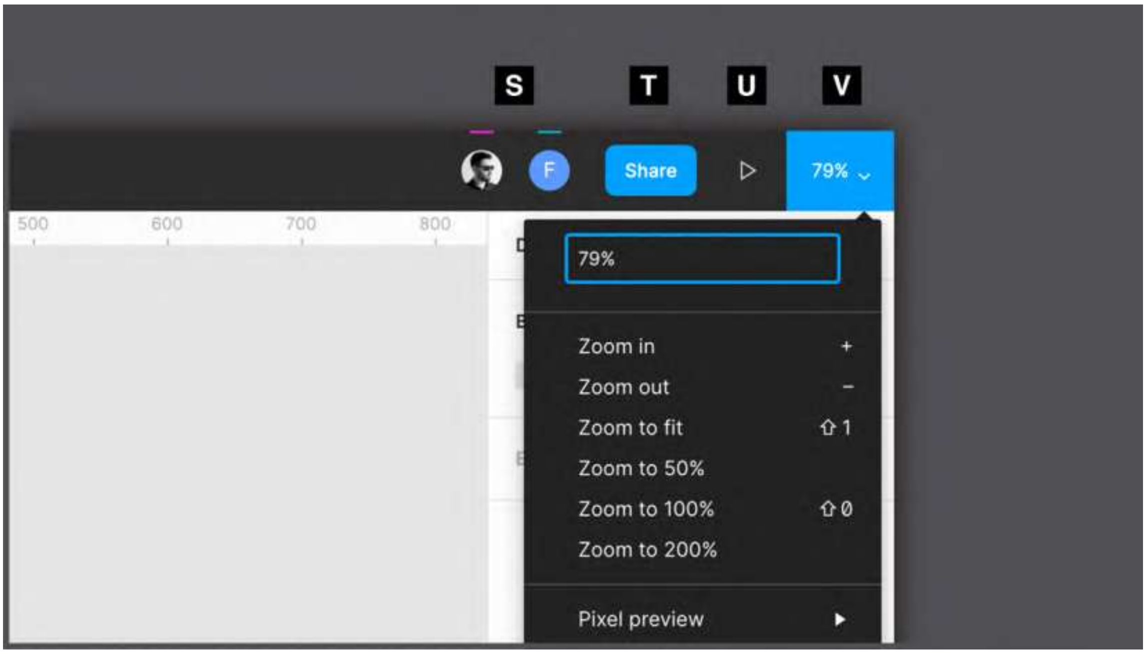

Figure 3.12 – The Collaboration, Testing, and View tools

T – share

This is a gateway to the many sharing opportunities that Figma offers. When you click on the **Share** button, a special dialog box will open where you can not only check the complete list of people who have access to this file and the permissions they have but also add new ones, or get a sharable link that allows you to invite anyone to the project. From here you can also make your project publicly available to the Figma Community. You will explore this opportunity in the last chapter of the book.

U – present

This is a function that will bring your design to life, allowing you to view both static previews of your chosen frames and complex interactive prototypes. The viewer opens in a separate tab and acts as a separate file, so you can share the preview with selected people or publicly while keeping the project source safe for yourself.

V – zoom/view

What you see here numerically is the current zoom value set in your workspace, and it changes in real time as you zoom in/out with your mouse wheel, pinching and zooming on a trackpad or with + and - keys on your keyboard. Clicking on it opens a drop-down menu dedicated to zooming and display settings, where you can not only use predefined functions to change zoom values but also manually set them by entering a number. There are also several toggles for options, such as the ability to activate or deactivate rulers.

Quick shortcuts

As you can see, Figma's top bar is the source of its core tools, some of which help you add elements to your design; others are for working with in your workspace. No doubt you can call this area very feature-rich. But the more you practice, the more you will understand how easy it is to find and switch from one tool to another. Your workflow will speed up even more if you implement the use of keyboard shortcuts in your daily work. Start with the easy ones and then little by little add more complex ones.

You can always check out all of the available keyboard shortcuts listed right in Figma, so you don't even need to consult the tutorials on the website or google anything. Just click **?** in the bottom right corner and select **Keyboard shortcuts**, or use the *Ctrl* + *Shift* + *?* key combination, and you will see a hotkeys panel sorted by the functions they run. Those filled with blue mean that you have already used them at least once; the gray shortcuts are those that you have not yet tested out:

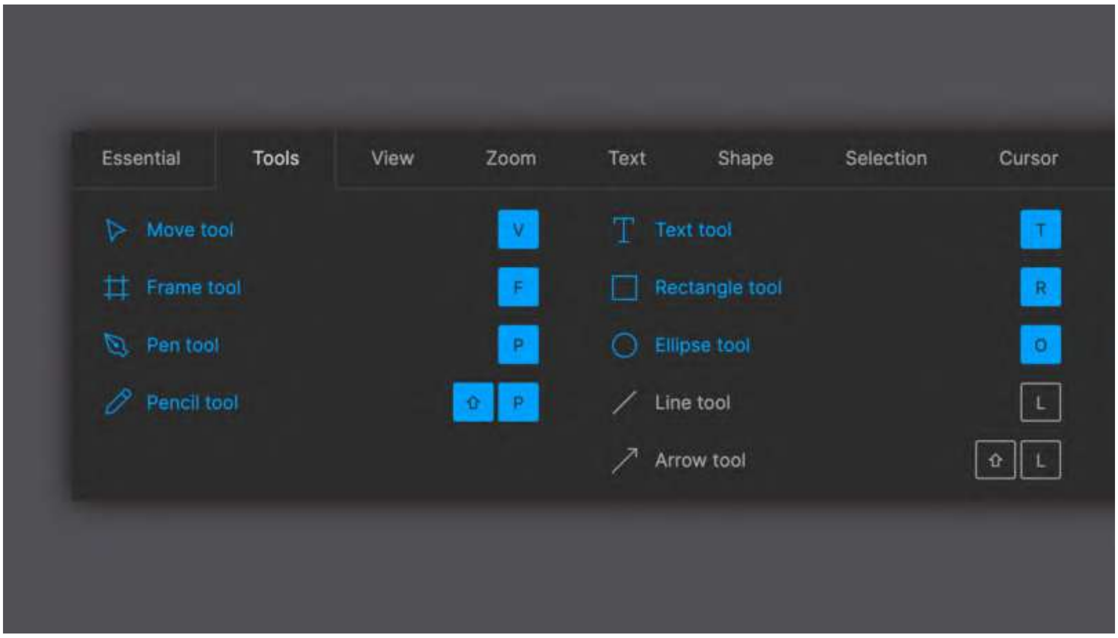

Figure 3.13 – The shortcut helper panel

So, now that you have a basic understanding of the general features of Figma and can add something to your workspace, it's time to see where you can access all the layers in your files.

Exploring the left panel

Learning Figma's tool sets can be challenging, but it is important to have at least a basic understanding of the features so you can quickly get started using them. Don't worry if you still feel insecure every time you launch Figma. You will soon learn the concept of each tool in a real workflow. However, tools are just one part of everything to learn in Figma. It is equally important to know how to work with layers and assets in your project. All of these will be displayed in the left sidebar, so let's take a deeper look at its interface.

Layers and pages

Every time you create a new text layer, shape, or any other element, its name is immediately displayed in the **Layers** panel. Likewise, when you delete an object from the work area (you can do this simply with the *Backspace* key on macOS or the *Delete* key on Windows), it will also be removed from the sidebar. So, think of the **Layers** panel as a container that collects everything in your project and helps you organize all the elements better:

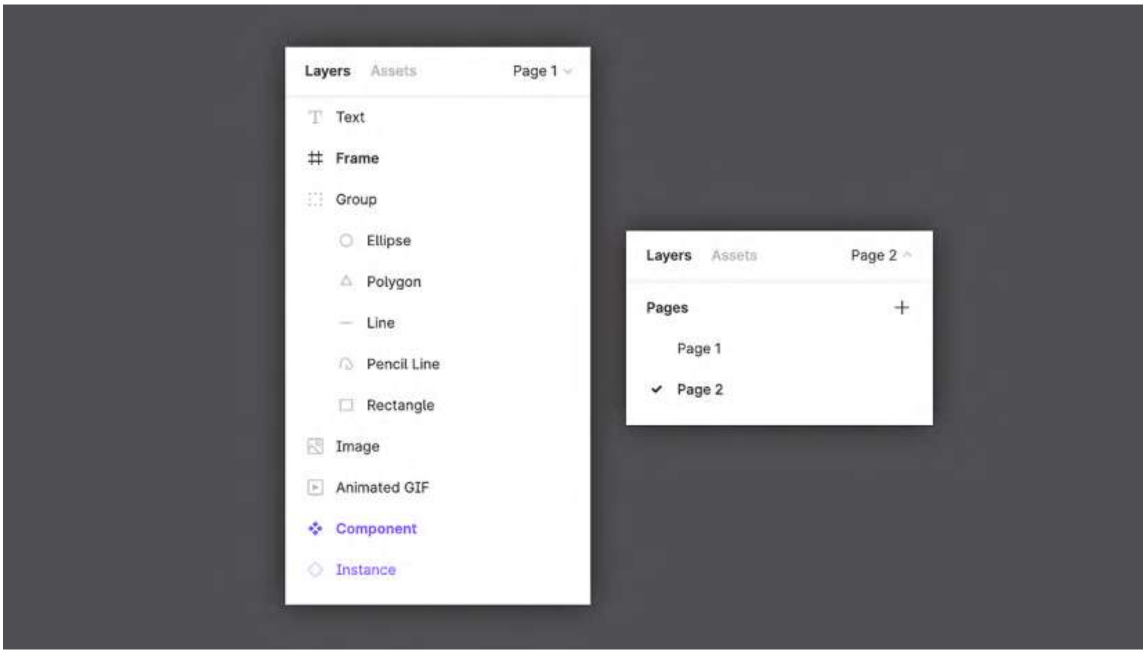

Figure 3.14 – The Layers and Pages panels

First of all, you should pay attention to the visual meaning of the icons in the panel and how they differ depending on the type of layer you are creating. A shape layer, for example, has a thumbnail of the shape itself. Don't worry if some of the layer types are not be familiar to you, you will soon be working with all of them, and as a result, you will remember every icon that appears in the panel.

The number of layers grows faster than you might imagine, so it's important to always keep them in order. It is very good practice to give each layer a suitable and meaningful name. However, be careful when moving the layers, because the hierarchy present in the **Layers** panel also reflects their order of depth on the canvas.

When there are too many layers to organize properly, pages come into play. Essentially, pages are separate workspaces, almost like independent files, but in fact, if they are placed in the same file, they belong to the same ecosystem, so you can freely use styles, resources, and more on all the pages. They are very useful for organizing, for example, different design stages in the same file. You will soon see how to build this kind of page structure in a file as efficiently as possible.

Assets

The **Assets** panel is an indispensable tab of the left panel that is used to organize all the elements of your design project for reuse. You haven't encountered components on your journey yet, which is one of the most important concepts in Figma, but this is not the place to get to know them. For now, you should just keep in mind that this is where you will soon be able to find them:

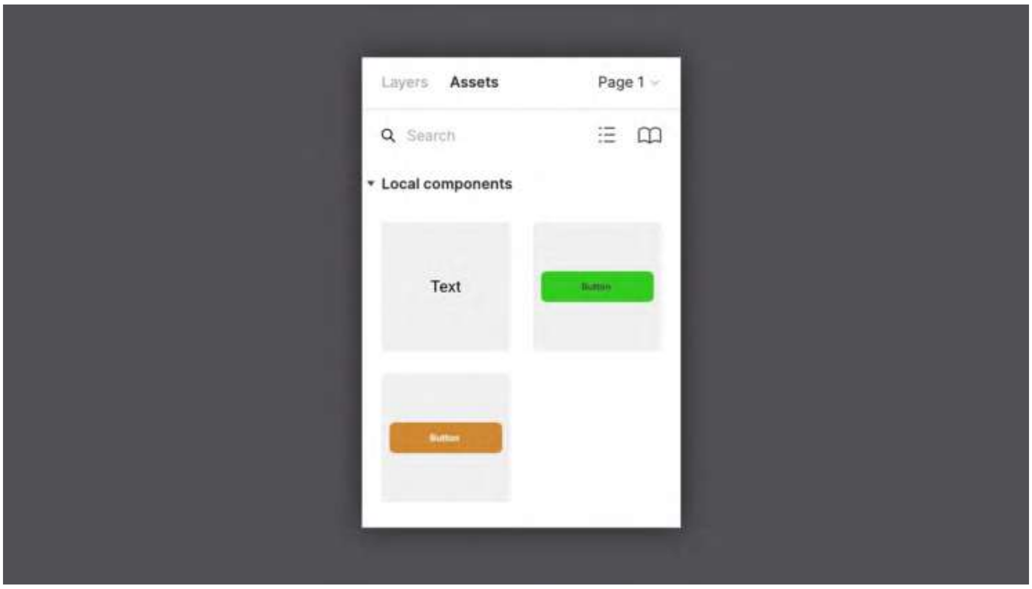

Figure 3.15 – The Assets panel

The more the **Assets** area begins to fill, the more difficult it becomes to visually search for the required components from the list. In this case, you should use the search bar at the top, which filters the results by the names assigned to the components. This is another good reason to choose the correct names for all of the elements – to make them easier to find.

Finally, in **Assets**, you can also find the team library (under the book-shaped icon), an incredible feature that lets you use styles and components from other files, personal or from the Figma Community.

So, now you know that on that left sidebar in Figma, you can see and organize your layers, add new pages, and find your assets quickly. This is still just a general overview of this panel, and you will inevitably get to know it deeper as you practice. Now, let's move on to the next section of the chapter, which will be devoted to the context-sensitive panel.

Exploring the right panel

Last but not least, you will explore the right panel, commonly referred to as the **Properties** panel. This area is context-sensitive, so it changes every time you click on something in your design file. Depending on the selected object, you can see different options, functions, and parameters. Therefore, it is better to learn and remember the functionality of the right panel in practice, and this section is just a short guide to it, which will simplify your further work. As you can see, the right sidebar is split into three tabs: **Design**, **Prototype**, and **Inspect**. Let's start and proceed in order.

Design

This is the panel tab that Figma opens by default, which makes sense, since you will no doubt use it the most. Whatever you're looking for about visual edits, you'll always find it in the **Design** panel. It sounds promising, but is it really so? If nothing is selected in your workspace, the panel may seem empty. But as soon as you click on any element on the canvas, you will see the required functions magically appearing there:

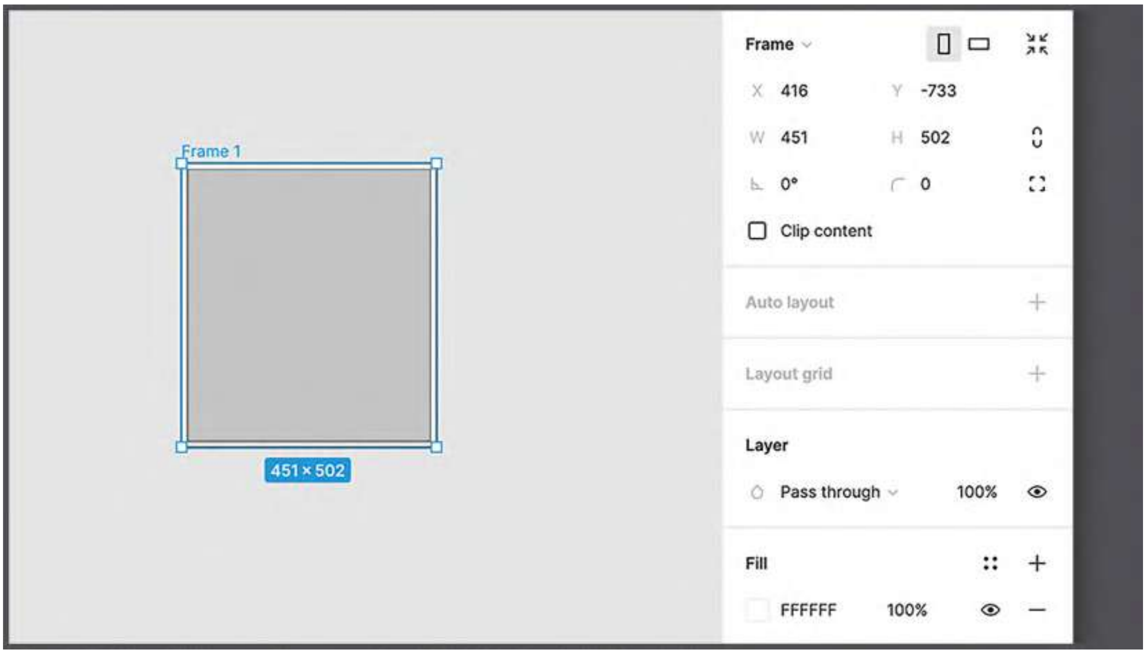

Figure 3.16 – The context-sensitive options of a frame

At first glance, this may seem tricky. So, to get a better understanding of the concept, ask yourself – would it be helpful to see the font size settings every time when working with a vector shape? Not at all. And therefore, in Figma, you will never see any function that is not needed or not usable at the moment.

Let's click on the frame you created earlier, which represents the screen size of the iPhone 11 Pro / X, and see what happens in the **Design** panel. Functions you've never seen before came out of nowhere. And if you look closely, you can see that all the options are absolutely consistent with the functionality of the frames. This way, you can change its size (manually or using the usual list of presets), the background color, corner rounding, and many other advanced features that you will discover later.

If you now try to deselect the frame by clicking anywhere outside the element, the **Design** panel will remove the display of all previous settings. You see that it is almost empty again and only offers you the option to change the background color of the workspace itself. You can do that if you ever need to increase the contrast between the design and the background.

It won't take you long to learn to appreciate the benefits of using context-sensitive functions, and soon you won't be able to imagine your workflow without them. But in case you're looking for a particular setting and can't find it, remember that most of the basic functionalities can also be accessed from the drop-down menu under the Figma icon in the upper left corner, or by right-clicking on any object in your workspace.

Prototype

The **Prototype** panel is fully consistent with the **Design** panel, allowing you to add interactions to your elements and presenting everything dynamically:

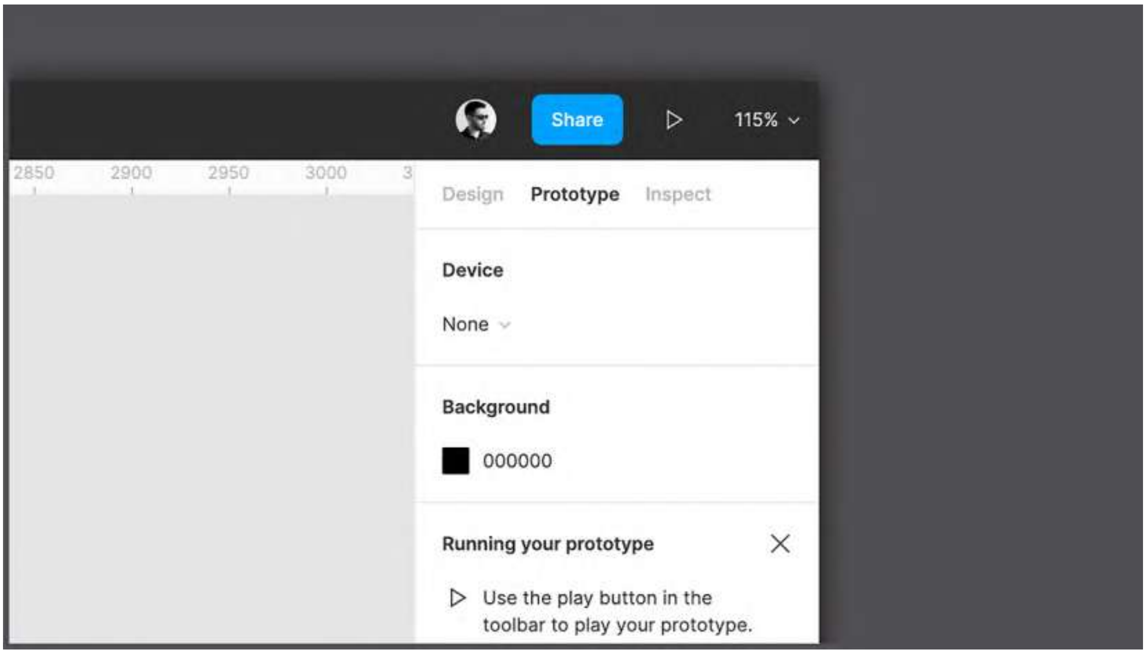

Figure 3.17 – The Prototype panel

This panel is also context-sensitive, so the settings you find here are related to the currently selected item and will be exclusively applicable to it. But in this case, however, not all elements really have functionality available upon selection. If you click on the text, for example, nothing will appear in the **Prototype** panel, just like clicking on a shape or image. This is because not all elements need to be made interactive.

Thus, the **Prototype** panel also has two states: inactive (after clicking anywhere outside of your elements in the workspace) and another state when frames or components are selected.

Inactive state

In the first state, as before, you are only allowed to change the background color of the canvas, plus you can see general project settings that are not specific to an individual element.

The first option presented in this panel is the **Device** section, which allows you to choose how the prototype will be displayed. If you open the drop-down list under the name of the section, you will see various presets for commonly used devices. You can choose any of the devices on the list, and for some models, there are even colors to choose from. As you remember, you previously selected the iPhone 11 Pro / X to set the size of your frame, but this does not mean that you will see this device in presentation mode. You can set this only by selecting the desired model in the **Device** section:

Figure 3.18 – The Frame Preview window

The next setting you'll notice is the background. Here you can set the background color for the prototyping screen if you want to change the color behind the selected device. You can also change the orientation of your device from portrait to landscape or vice versa.

When a frame or component is selected

Like the **Design** panel, **Prototype** is also context-sensitive. Thus, after selecting any frame or component on the canvas, instead of the device and background settings, the panel will display other more advanced features. In this case, Figma will not prompt you to make any changes to your objects but will offer functions for interacting with your elements on the screen, such as what follows a button press or the choice of scrolling direction:

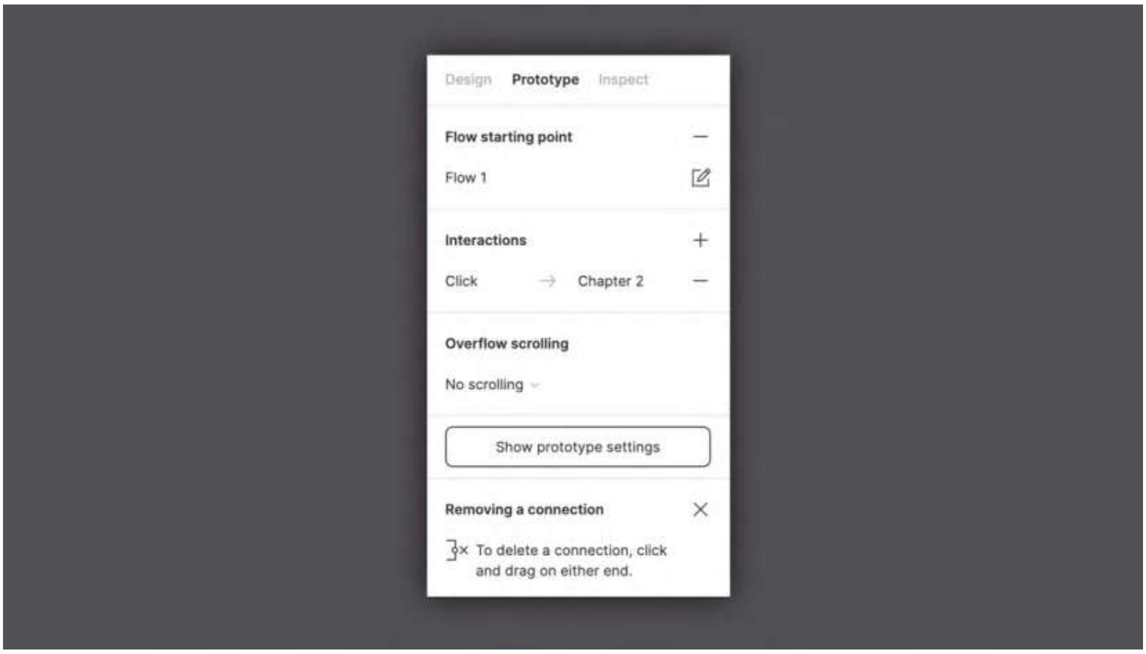

Figure 3.19 – The Prototype panel with an active selection

At first glance, the **Prototype** section might not seem as equipped with various settings as the **Design** panel. But its simplification is justified by the fact that everything here is done extremely intuitively. The entire interaction system plays on the mechanics of "if this, then that", allowing you to select an element, assign it an action type (touch, click, hover, and so on), and determine the result that this action will produce – for example, moving to another page, or opening or closing an overlay.

One of the most recent additions to the **Prototype** panel is the **Flows** section, which was a very significant upgrade. This feature allows you to create more than one flow in the same project file to compare or test different realizations of the same scenario.

Are you curious to know more about all this? Don't worry – in *Chapter 9, Prototyping with Transitions, Smart Animate and Interactive Components,* and *Chapter 10, Testing and Sharing your Prototype on Browsers and Real Devices*, you will have the opportunity to explore in depth the amazing power of prototyping in Figma.

Inspect

As mentioned earlier, the tabbing of the right sidebar is logical and consistent across the phases of the project, and the **Inspect** panel comes in useful mostly when your design is complete and the flow is approved:

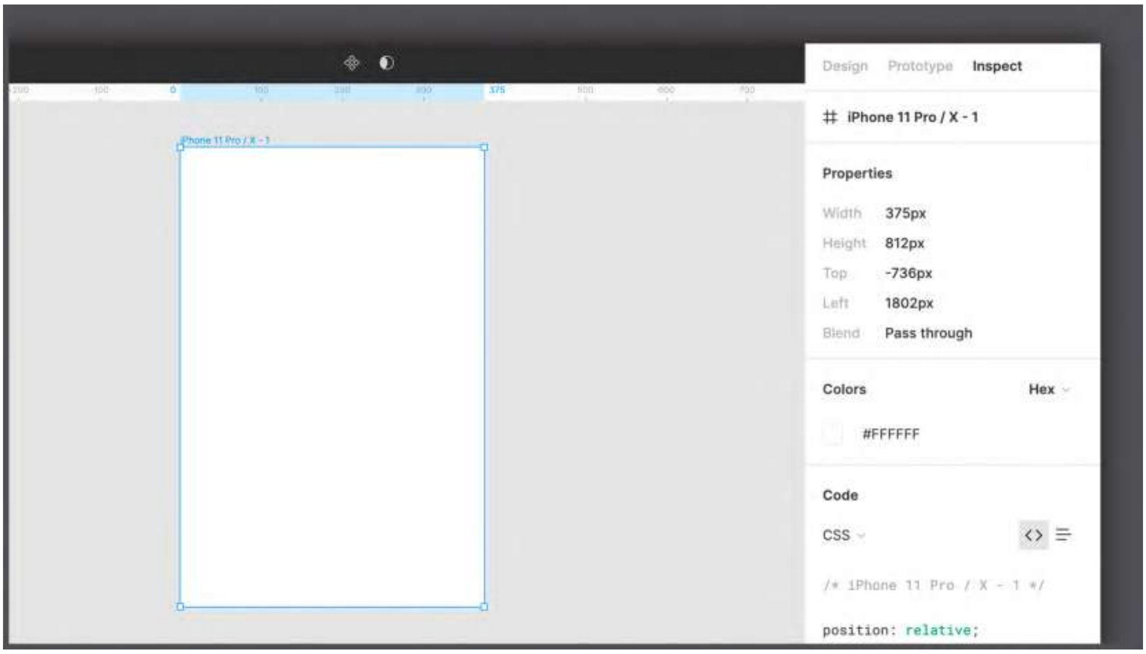

Figure 3.20 – The Inspect panel

The **Inspect** panel will be your bridge for effective communication with developers who are responsible for transforming your design into code. Here you can not only find the necessary raw data about element sizing, positioning, and so on but also see how to convert some of this data directly into code snippets.

Figma offers three available code transformations – CSS (web development), iOS (Swift), and Android (XML). But be careful in relying too much on this function, as it does not guarantee the exact implementation of your design in code. Think of it more as a tool to support developers, who will have quick access to an overview of information such as size, color, and position of any element, or even font size, font family, and font weight in the case of text layers. Instead of spending a lot of time to determine the correct attributes, they can check the **Inspect** panel and see everything displayed in code.

Help Center

As you can see, the right sidebar contains three tabs that represent the three phases of the user interface – design, prototyping, and exporting. It is in this order that you will get more and more practice, and as a result, you will learn how to use each function in the all panels in this area.

If you have any difficulty finding information about any Figma tool or want to refer to official resources, you can always do this in the **Help Center** by clicking the floating circle button with **?** in the lower right corner. Here you can find links to content from the official website, Figma YouTube videos, the support forum, and so on. So, all you need now is a bit of patience and a willingness to further explore Figma!

Summary

Well, if you feel like all the new information you've just received is too much to remember, you're probably right. When getting started in Figma especially, it takes time to get used to its interface and become fluent with its features. That's why it is highly recommended to return to this chapter from time to time to refresh your memory about the toolbar, and the left and right panels.

Now that you've successfully completed this chapter, you can see the true capacity of Figma and how powerful it can be in many ways. To help you create high-quality designs in the best possible way, Figma never stops working on introducing new features into its own interface. Stay tuned to the official Figma Twitter profile (`@figmadesign`) for new features and releases, and try testing them and incorporating them into your work routine so that Figma's tools will have nothing mysterious or unknown to you.

From now on, with each next chapter, you will get more and more practice with Figma! In the next chapter, you'll start working on your first wireframe, using shapes and other basic elements. Get ready for an exciting new challenge!

4
Wireframing a Mobile-First Experience Using Vector Shapes

You've reached the point where you have essential knowledge of the UX process and Figma's interface. Now it's time to put it all together and get started with the user interface of our streaming service application. As mentioned previously, it is best to always keep all the artifacts collected during the UX phase nearby – the mission statement, persona, user flow, and other data. In this chapter, you will take a significant step toward moving from theory and hypotheses to creating a real application structure using the wireframe method!

This is a very important part of product development, but there is nothing to worry about, since this chapter will guide you through the entire process of this phase. However, before moving on to wireframing, you will need to have a basic understanding of what it is and why it is so helpful for all UX/UI designers, no matter how much experience they have. You will also learn the tools you will need in this step and practice using them right on the canvas.

So, this time, the information will be quite varied, but by the end of the chapter, all the knowledge and skills that you have gained so far will magically turn into something directly related to your first prototype of a mobile application in Figma!

In this chapter, we are going to cover the following main topics:

- Evolving the idea to a wireframe
- Playing with shapes in Figma
- Advanced vectors with the Pen tool
- Developing the app structure

Evolving the idea to a wireframe

Since the analysis and research phase are completed and the idea is approved, you are ready to turn it into something real. This time, you'll learn how to create a skeleton for our previously introduced streaming service application, which is a wired structure for visualizing and experimenting with usability and product functionality. This is an important process called wireframing that takes place before you start designing the first prototype and allows you to choose the right product structure. There is some theoretical knowledge that you should know about this step, so in this section, you will learn some of the important concepts about the interface and the related navigation elements.

What is a wireframe?

If you are a beginner, you may not know what a wireframe is and what it is for. Perhaps you cannot wait to finally get to work on a real design, and this step may seem like one more obstacle. But wireframing is a crucial part of the process of creating a product that is really useful and practical. Over time, you will understand more deeply the incredible value of all the early design stages, and they will become a natural part of your workflow. The initial impulse to jump straight to style and color choices is common among those approaching design projects, but you should always remember that a designer's job is mostly about research, analysis, and problem-solving rather than creativity.

So, what is a wireframe? Basically, it is the first draft of a raw UI without any style, detail, or even color. The first iteration of the wireframe can also be done roughly with pen and paper (*Figure 4.1*), but this time you'll create it right in Figma so that you can practice what you've learned in the previous chapters. To start, you need to go back to the FigJam files with all your artifacts, most notably the user persona and the user flow, because at this stage, your decisions will be based on all the data that you have collected for product development:

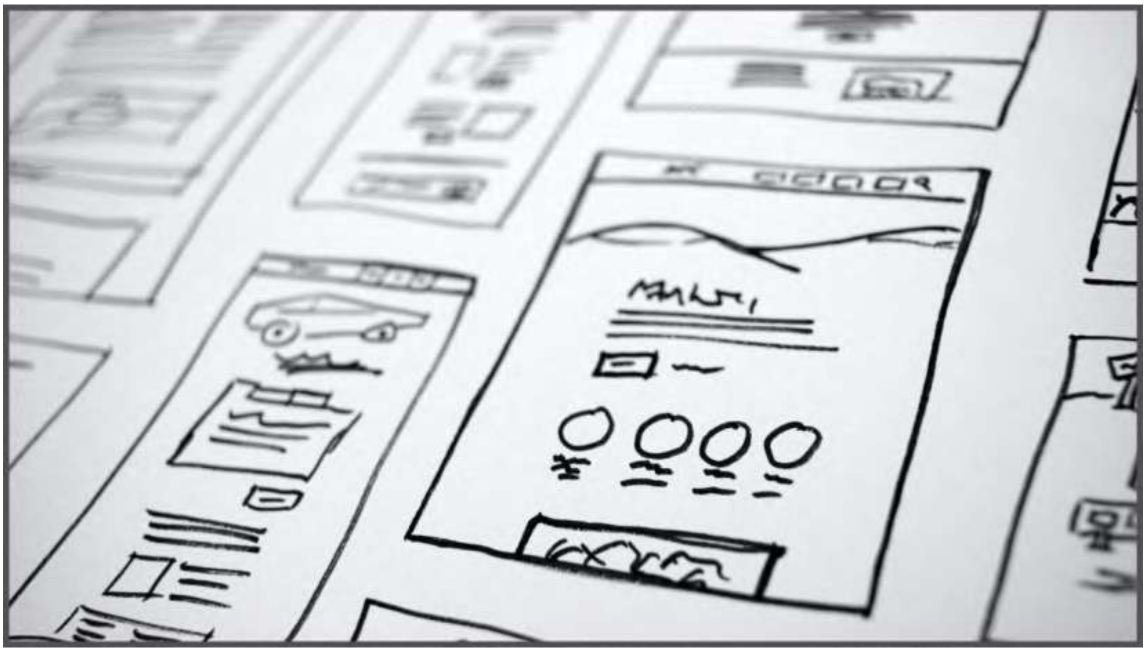

Figure 4.1 – A paper wireframe example
(Photo by Halacious on Unsplash)

The wireframing itself does not take too long, and even a very raw draft can help identify problems during user testing. Thus, you can make any changes at an early stage and better work out the usability of a product based on the testers' feedback. If you skip the wireframe stage and jump straight to UI design, you run the risk of revealing all the problems in the near-final version of the product. As a result, you will inevitably spend a lot more time working because it will take a huge effort to make changes to an already polished prototype.

Don't worry if you still can't come up with a clear idea of a real wireframe that can be applied to our brief. You will soon learn how to structure it, and everything will become much clearer.

Why mobile-first?

Before proceeding directly with the creation of the wireframe, you have to select an initial product format. It is clear that this will depend on what is planned to be developed. For example, if you are creating a product that will be used primarily on a computer, the desktop screen will be the starting frame. And since the mobile version is secondary to this particular product, you can get started with it later.

However, in most cases, you will usually choose the smallest initial format, which is the format of mobile devices. Is this just a set rule? Not really. The reason for this choice is based on the analysis of statistical data. For several years now, people have been using smartphones instead of desktops to browse the web and use apps for basic internet operations. So, because of this significant change in the behavior of people in the digital space, except in special cases, the design of the interface has become primarily focused on mobile devices.

But even when choosing a mobile device as the primary format, a new dilemma arises as to which screen resolution to go for, since it can vary from device to device. Except in special cases where there is exact data on which smartphone model will be used by the majority of the users, it is better to stick to a medium-resolution mobile device format. Then, you can gradually increase the size of screens to higher resolutions for smartphones, then tablets, and finally desktops and TVs.

We will not design for every Android device and all iPhone models. It would be useless, since the main goal is not to release a real product but to design a product that can become a detailed blueprint for developers.

So, let's set up our application for release on a mobile device, a tablet, and a computer. And for the wireframe, the standard screen of the mobile device will be selected. At later stages of the work, an adaptive approach will be integrated to account for all intermediate resolutions and to ensure that the product works well on all available devices, without leaving anything to chance.

Now you know what is behind the creation of the skeleton of the future application interface and what the initial screen size should be for it. But before you start drawing in Figma, you'll learn and practice some of the tools you need to create your first wireframe.

Playing with shapes in Figma

You are already familiar with many of the basic tools in Figma, but so far, you have not tested them much. This is not a problem, as you will try out every useful feature actively, which you will start doing right now. And you don't have to worry about knowing any advanced tools to create a wireframe; all you need is simple geometric shapes.

Basic shapes

As you already know, the top toolbar has a **Shape** tool that allows you to add different geometric shapes that you can then edit on the canvas. Besides basic shapes such as ellipses and rectangles, you can use more complex ones. For example, the **Star** tool creates a classic five-pointed star by default, but the element can be edited after it is added to the canvas. You can change the number of the star points, increasing or decreasing them by clicking the **Count** handle (*Figure 4.2*) and dragging the cursor up or down:

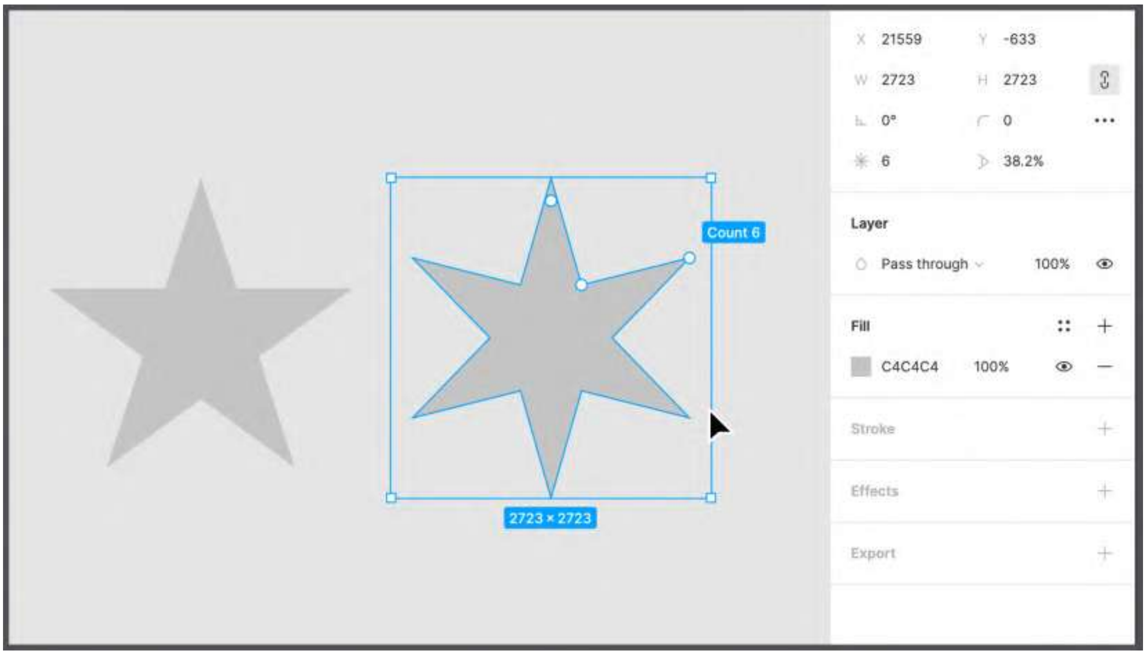

Figure 4.2 – Editing a star

Likewise, with the **Polygon** tool, you can create a default triangular shape and then increase the number of sides, thus creating more complex shapes, such as pentagons and hexagons. The other shape-editing handle, **Radius**, allows you to quickly adjust the roundness of each shape.

The **Ellipse** tool seems simple because you can obviously expect it to create circles or ellipses. But with the **Ellipse** tool, you can also create pie charts very easily. How? Draw a circle on the canvas, select it, and hover over it so that an **Arc** handle appears. Dragging this marker inside the circle creates a gap that allows you to create accurate pie charts. Moreover, this change will cause other markers to appear on your circle: **Sweep**, **Start**, and **Ratio**. The first one is the one we have already used earlier; the second allows you to rotate the starting point of the gap; and finally, the third transforms the circle into a ring, moving toward the center of the ellipse:

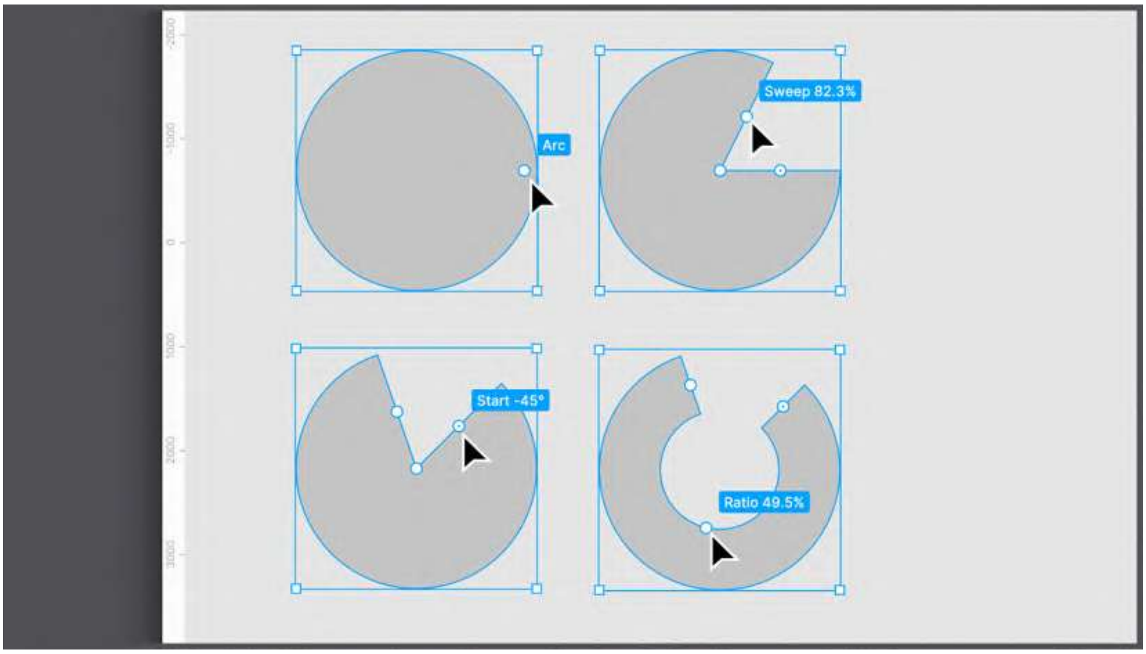

Figure 4.3 – A circle's edit handles

> **Note**
>
> By holding down the *Shift* key while resizing the shape, you can easily keep its proportions. If you instead press and hold the *Option* key (macOS) or *Alt* (Windows), the shape will be resized from its center. You can also use both keys together to resize the shape proportionally to its center. Feel free to experiment with these tricks on different shapes and elements!

You might have noticed that whatever shape you add to the canvas, Figma will automatically apply a default style to it, which is a gray background color and nothing else. This default style is sufficient to create your first wireframe, but you can make the flow more intuitive and functional with even minor additions to this style. For example, you can highlight elements that represent a suggested user path with a brighter color. This allows you to see immediately which actions will lead a user to the intended action.

Changing the style of a shape is easy. To do this, select any element in your working area, and you'll see that the right sidebar will show you the available style options. You can experiment with colors and other styles if you like, but you'll soon get to know each one in detail.

As mentioned earlier, any shape you add to the canvas is a vector, so you can edit it however you like. Just click a shape and press *Enter*, or double-click it, to activate edit mode:

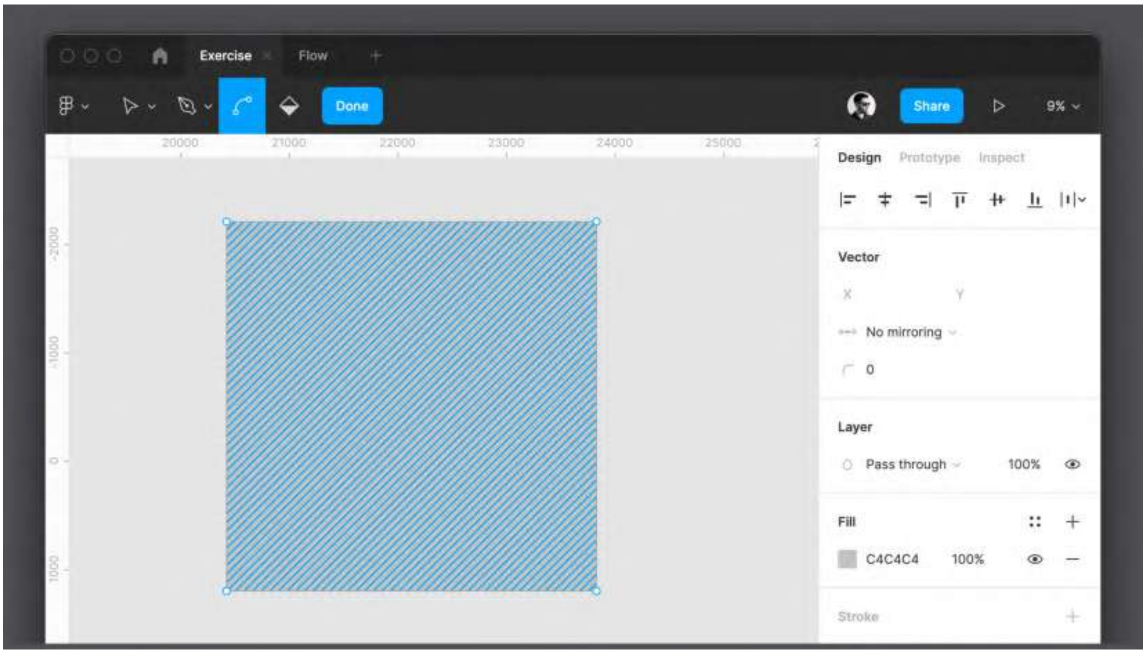

Figure 4.4 – Vector's edit mode

From now on, you can edit each point of the selected shape, or even add new points with the **Pen** tool. And that is not all. In edit mode, the regular Figma toolbar tools are replaced with some dedicated advanced vector editing tools. With the **Bend** tool, for example, you can click and drag any point on a shape and convert it to a curve. When you are finished editing the shape, click **Done** on the toolbar to exit edit mode, or press the *Enter* key again.

Edit mode is incredibly powerful, and you will need to take some time to learn how it works. Don't worry – in the next section of this chapter, you will find detailed information on the vector graphics capabilities and the functionality of the **Pen** tool in Figma, and this will be your starting point for practice on your own.

Combining shapes

You may have noticed that after you select any shape on the board, a new set of icons appears in the center of the top toolbar, where the filename is usually displayed. You can access even more features by selecting two or more items together. To do this, drag a selection on those elements by holding down the left mouse button, or simply click one of the shapes first, and then the rest while holding down the *Shift* key. Once selected, you will see three icons in the middle of the top toolbar, and the last of them, which is the Boolean groups, can only be applied to a group of objects, not a single element.

Using this newly discovered set of functions, you can perform many different operations on a group of objects. If you choose two shapes, you can, for example, combine them in a special way. To understand better, let's try to create a crescent using two circles:

1. Create the first circle by selecting an ellipse in the shapes or by pressing the *O* key on your keyboard. Remember to hold down the *Shift* key while drawing to get a perfectly round circle.
2. Change the default circle background color by selecting it and clicking the colored square below the **Fill** section in the right sidebar. A new window will appear with a color selector. Just pick any shade of yellow:

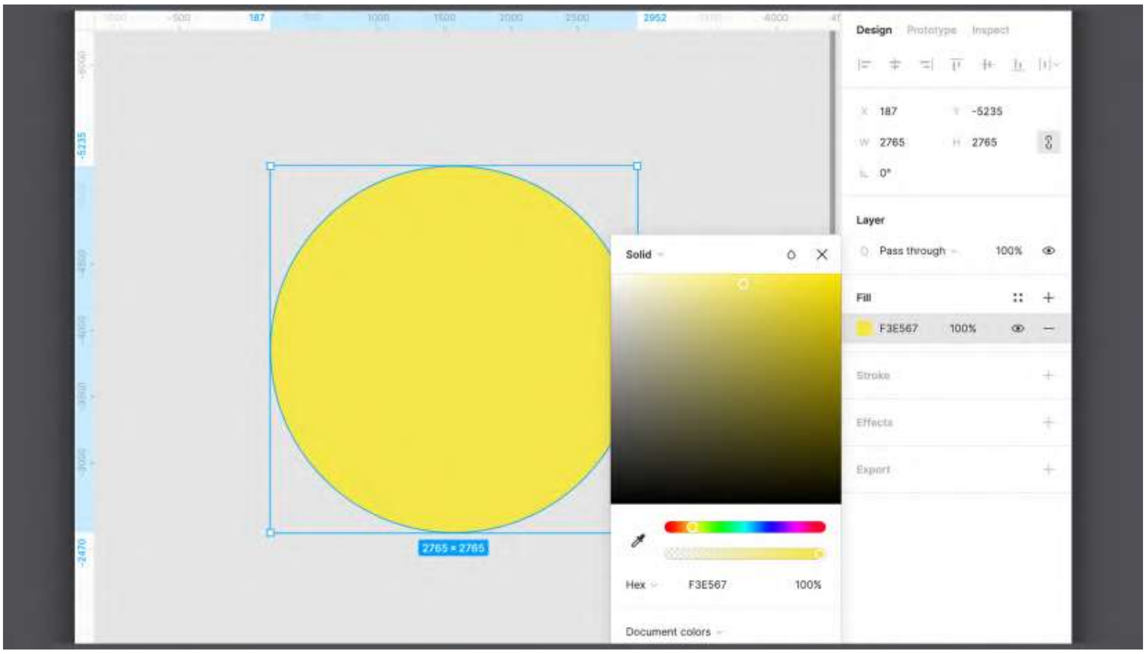

Figure 4.5 – Selecting a color

3. Duplicate the yellow circle by clicking and dragging it slightly to the right while holding down the *Option* key (macOS) or *Alt* (Windows), or alternatively, by using the *Command* + *D* (macOS) or *Ctrl* + *D* (Windows) keyboard shortcut. These shortcuts make it easy to duplicate any layer.
4. Select both shapes.
5. Click the drop-down arrow of the third icon in the center of the toolbar – the Boolean group – and choose **Subtract selection**. This will use the layer above to subtract from the layer below:

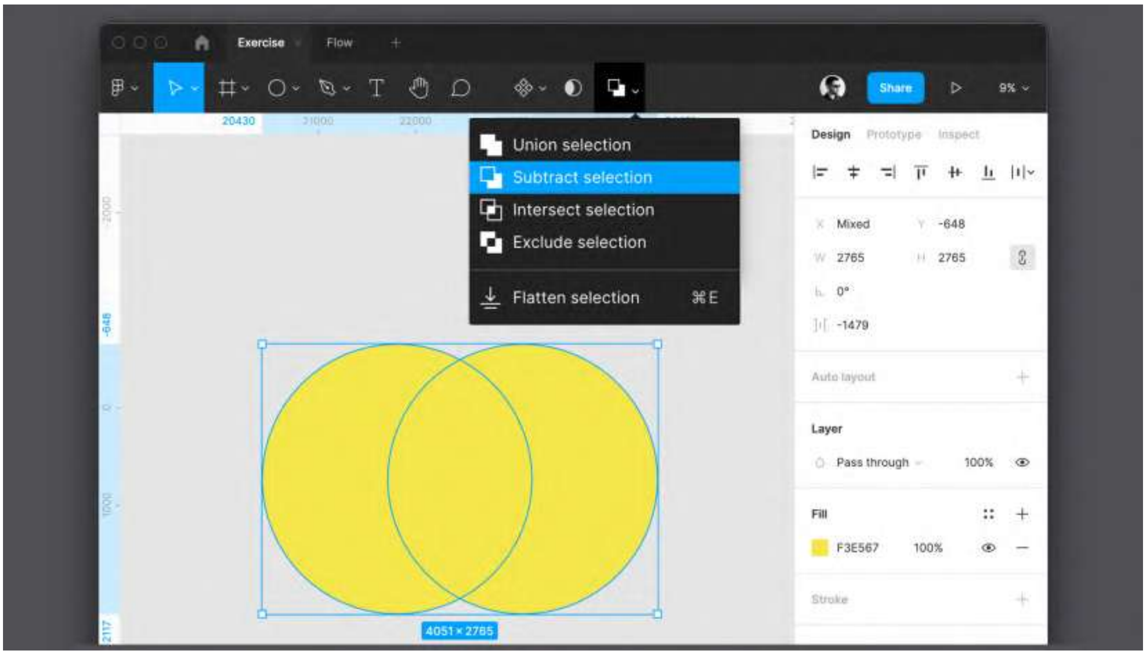

Figure 4.6 – Subtract selection

The end result will be our crescent.

Each of the functions in this drop-down menu allows you to get a different result, from combining individual shapes to excluding or intersecting selected shapes:

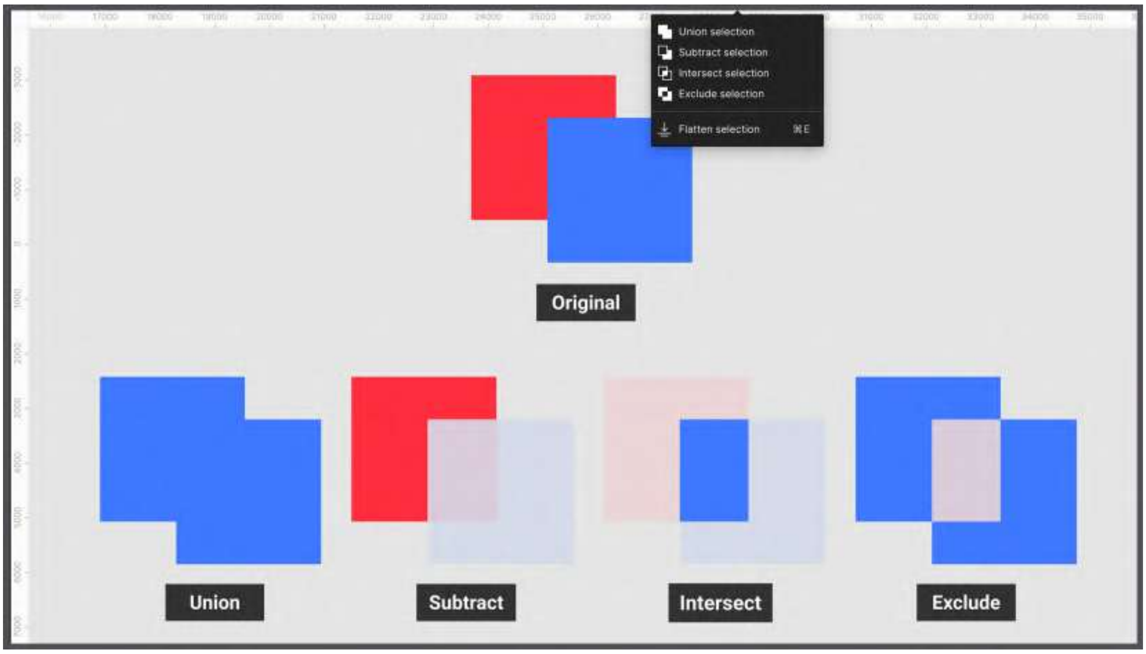

Figure 4.7 – The vector's Boolean groups

Almost all of the functions in this menu are pretty simple and clear, and you can test them by yourself on any two shapes you select. However, the **Flatten** function, which can also be run using the *Command* + *E* (macOS) or *Ctrl* + *E* (Windows) key combination, requires a detailed study. Flatten selection allows you to combine multiple shapes into a single vector while still preserving each shape's outline (you can find a visual example of this in *Figure 4.8* as follows, showing you the difference between shapes combined with **Union** and **Flatten**). This is possible due to Figma's incredible vector network feature, which we'll explore in the next section of this chapter:

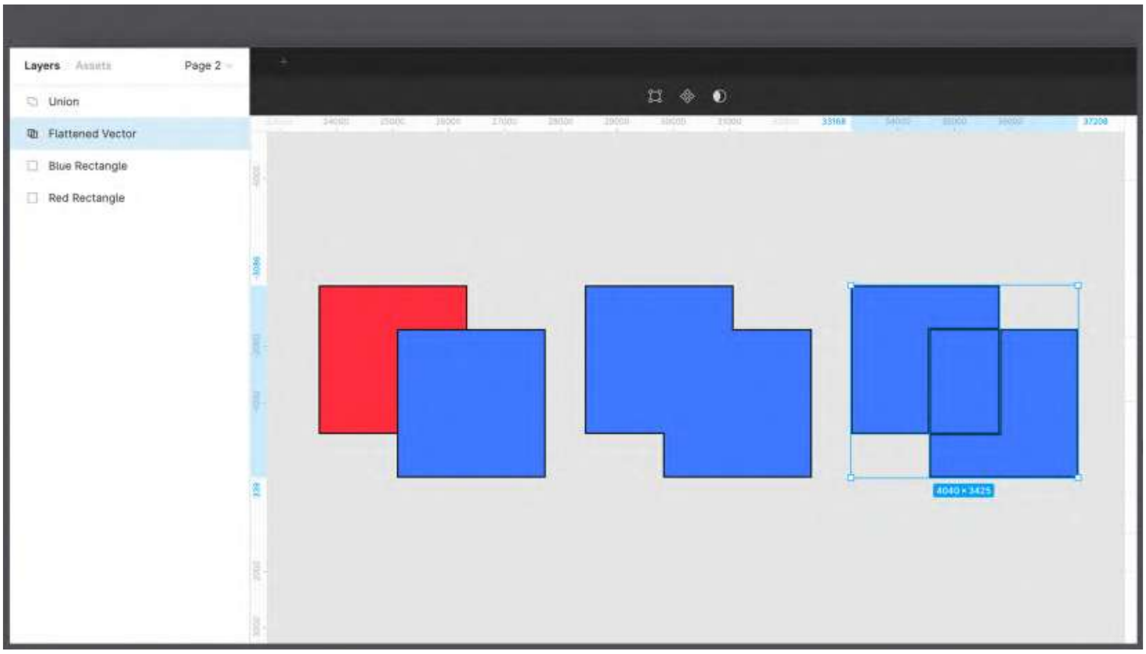

Figure 4.8 – The differences between Normal, Union, and Flatten

You've now learned a whole bunch of new tools that will make it really easy to get more complex shapes. The next topic in the chapter will be devoted to the more advanced features of Figma, and you will know how to effectively work with vectors.

Advanced vectors with the Pen tool

Before you get into practice with our brief, let's dive deeper into the principles of working with vectors. Vector graphics are one of the main concepts that need to be studied in detail, as you will definitely use them very often when working with Figma. The topic of this section of the chapter may seem more complex than what you learned earlier. This is why it is highly recommended not only to follow the instructions that you'll find here but also to practice on your own. Feel free to refer to the following information as many times as you need; try experimenting and getting creative with vectors to master this tool as quickly as possible!

What are vector graphics?

So, as you already know, the elements that you have created with the **Shape** tool so far are vectors; they are composed of lines, curves, and shapes, and are generated using mathematical formulas. Vector graphics are very helpful for several reasons. First of all, using them, you can freely scale anything without losing quality – from a simple shape to a complex illustration. This magic happens because when you resize a vector shape, Figma recalculates the data that it is composed of, so the result of the resized shape or image will not be grainy. In contrast, raster (or bitmap) images – for example, a `.jpeg` photo imported into Figma – are composed of a finite amount of data, which is a grid of pixels of specific sizes, where each pixel is associated with an exact color. If you double the size of this bitmap image, there is not enough chromatic information at its disposal to cover this mesh, and you end up with a grainy, low-quality image that should be absolutely avoided in production:

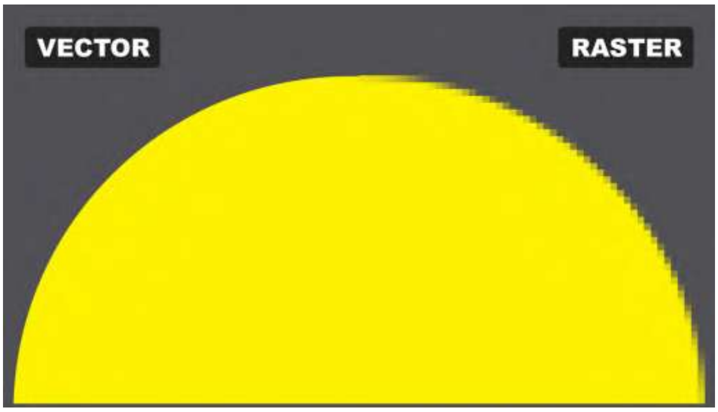

Figure 4.9 – Vector versus raster

Another advantage of a vector object is that it is very easy to edit and, more incredibly, it is very light in file size. But if vector graphics have so many advantages, why do you need bitmap at all? The point is that vector graphics are not suitable for all situations. For example, a photograph cannot be vectorized, unless you want to more or less accurately redraw it as a stylish illustration, since complex details, light, and shadows cannot be reproduced with lines, curves, primitives, and intersecting shapes.

When it comes to logos, icons, and illustrations, it's always best to create them in vector format. But how do you know that you have a vector and not a raster object? Everything that is created initially in Figma is already vector by default. But when you import an external element, you need to check the file extension – for example `.JPEG` or `.PNG` files can never be vectors. The most common format for vector content is **Scalable Vector Graphics** (**SVG**), which has increased in use in recent years thanks to its support in modern browsers and operating systems. Because of the simplicity of vector editing, SVG has also become incredibly efficient for animation.

> **Note**
>
> You can move vector shapes from Adobe Illustrator to Figma by simply copying and pasting them. Instead, if you want to do the opposite, right-click the shape in Figma and choose **Copy | Paste | Copy as SVG**. Go back to Illustrator and paste by pressing *Command* + *V* (macOS) or *Ctrl* + *V* (Windows).

There are also other vector file extensions such as `.AI` (**Adobe Illustrator**), `.EPS` (**Encapsulated PostScript**), and `.PDF` (**Portable Document Format**). These are proprietary formats, and you need to convert them to SVG before importing them into Figma. However, you should be aware that the extension is still not enough to be sure that you are using vectors because any of these file formats can contain some bitmap objects as well. You can check this by simply resizing the object. A vector element will always have smooth and sharp edges, no matter how large you make it. Also, you can recognize elements by their layer's icon, since raster images have the classic icon that represents a picture while a vector is represented with a custom shape icon.

Now that you understand some of the key concepts of the vector format, let's see how to create more complex vector elements with the incredibly powerful **Pen** tool.

Discovering the Pen tool

If you already have some experience with design applications, you probably know a form of the **Pen** tool – one that lets you create vector points, lines, and curves to create complex shapes. In fact, this is not a Figma-exclusive tool but a must in any design app.

This tool may seem very difficult to master at first, but once you understand its basic mechanics and then explore its powerful capabilities, it can become your favorite tool.

First, let's draw some simple lines and curves:

1. Select the **Pen** tool (*P*). You will see the cursor turning into a pen, ready to use.
2. Click anywhere on the canvas to place the first starting point. From now on, you will see the line following the cursor – consider this as a preview, showing you what your vector will look like if you click elsewhere again.

3. Let's create a straight horizontal line. Move the cursor slightly to the right of the first point, and when you are satisfied with the line shown in the preview, just click again. You will notice that it wasn't hard to be precise because Figma helps you draw straight lines with magnetic sensitive guides active by default:

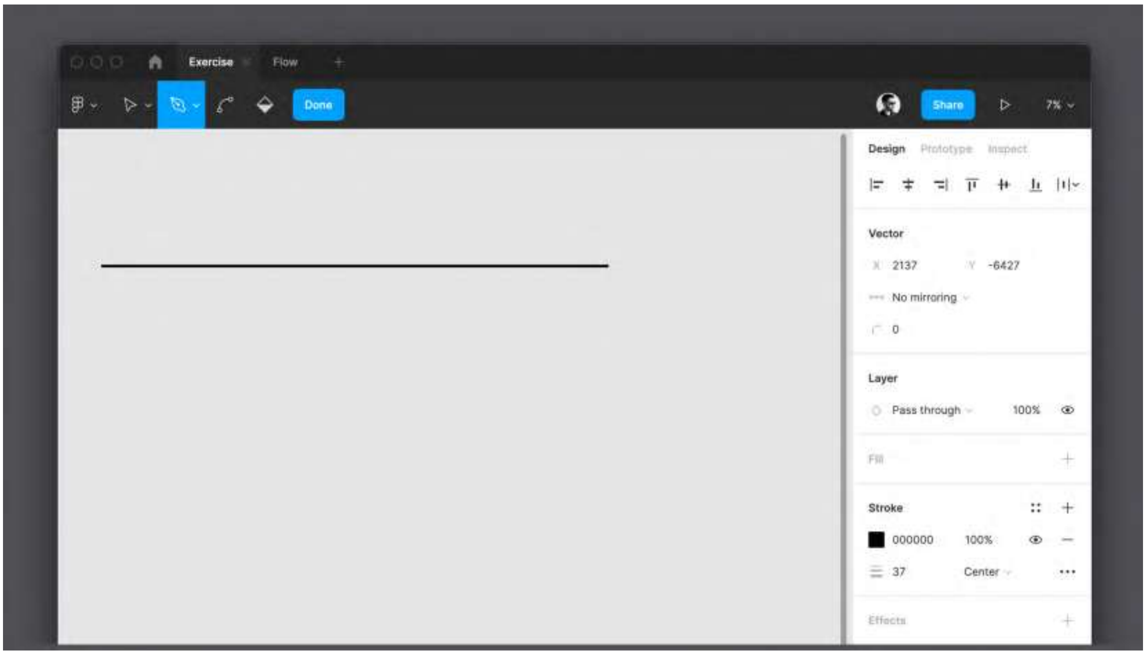

Figure 4.10 – A straight line made with the Pen tool

From now on, you can create as many points and lines as you want to achieve the desired shape. This was just one way to use the **Pen** tool; let's now move on to drawing your first curved line:

1. Select the **Pen** tool (*P*) again.
2. Click anywhere on the canvas to place the starting point. Make sure you are creating a new shape and not connecting your point to the shape from the previous example.

3. Move the cursor slightly to the right of the first point, and this time, click and drag. You will see that your line will now be curved, and the more you drag, the more pronounced the curve will be:

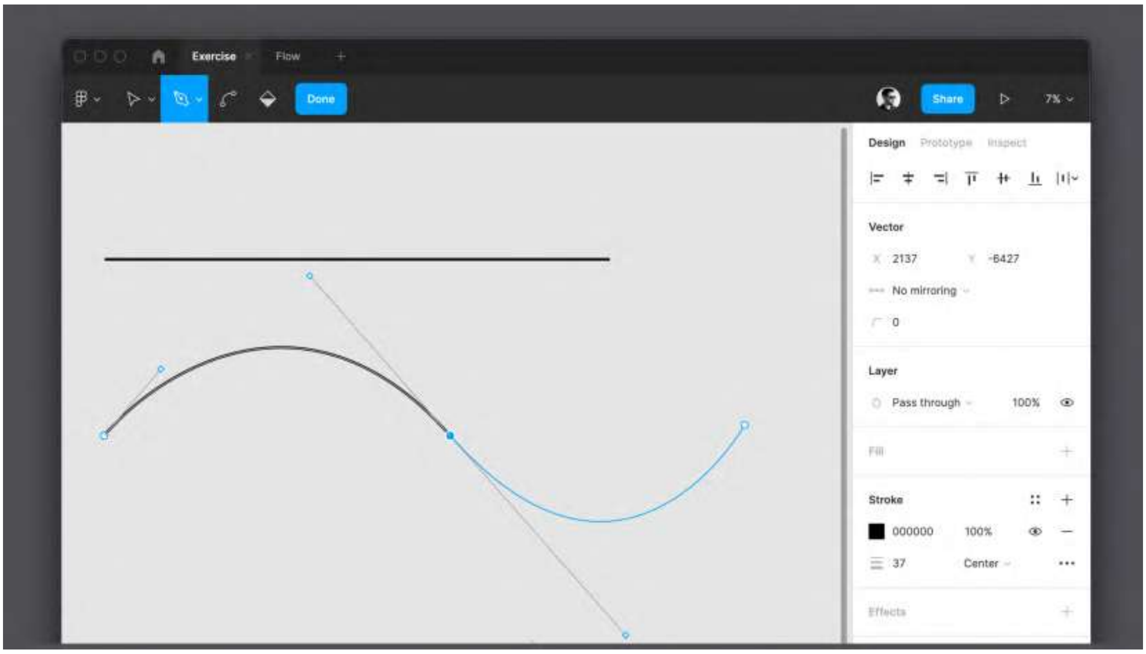

Figure 4.11 – The Pen tool with a Bézier curve example

Great! You've just created your first Bézier curve. Now, you can see that you have not only got two points and a line but also a few new handles to play with, positioned respectively before and after the curve point you have placed. The first handle changes the trend of the curve that you have already drawn, and the second allows you to anticipate and change, if needed, the direction, angle, and length of the next line or curve that you are going to draw.

If you connect the last point you created with the starting point, then this way, you get a closed shape, for which you can further customize the final result by adding, for example, a fill color in the **Design** panel. Try gradually to make more and more complex shapes with just a single line, like the one in the following screenshot:

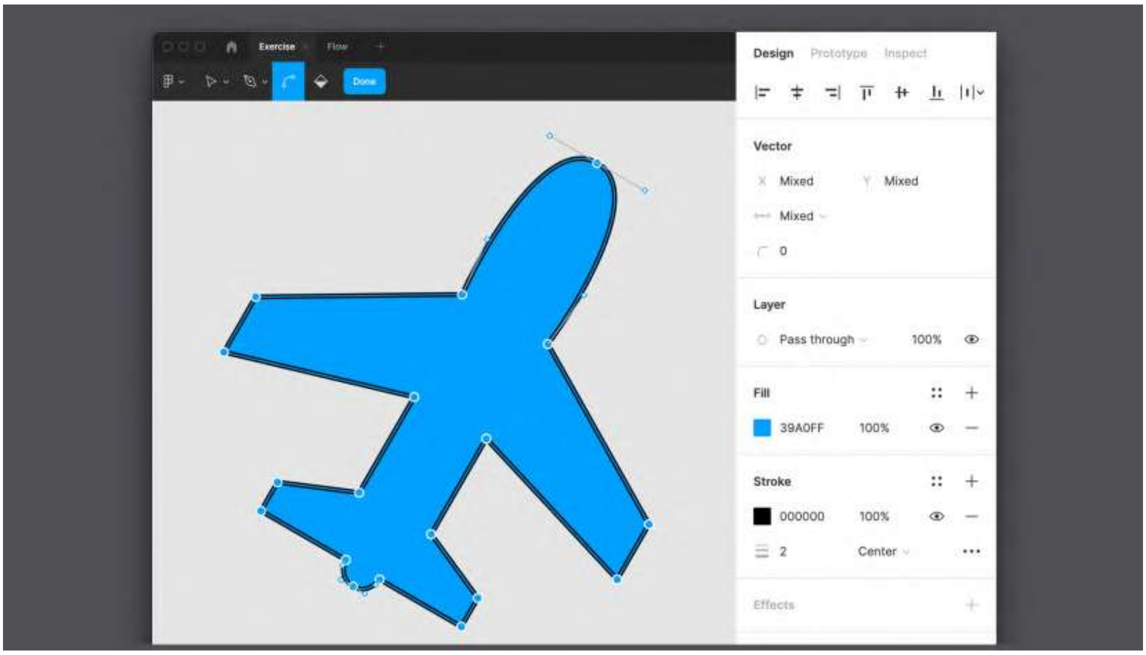

Figure 4.12 – A complex vector example

All the lines and shapes that you create with the **Pen** tool are absolutely consistent with the original default shapes that you have already encountered. This means that you can combine, for example, a rectangle and a complex custom shape to get a whole new bunch of shapes.

Likewise, you can modify any line or shape created with the **Pen** tool at any time by switching to edit mode (by selecting the shape and pressing *Enter* or double-clicking on it). In this mode, you can not only move points and add new ones but also change corner points, smoothing them using the aforementioned **Bend** tool. You can also switch between a smooth and straight corner by holding *Command* (macOS) or *Ctrl* (Windows) and clicking the vector point you want to change.

Vector networks

In any other tool for vector graphics, the vector has very specific characteristics and is distinguished in open and closed paths. The path is defined as closed when the first point coincides with the last of a shape, thus generating a filled area. Figma, however, introduces a new concept – vector networks – a unique feature that allows you to push the boundaries of vectors even further.

While the standard vector is unidirectional, vector networks do not have a specific direction and can be closed by connecting any points, not necessarily the first and the last. This allows you to draw much more complex vector shapes in Figma without the need to merge many shapes and create multiple layers. One such example can be seen in the following screenshot:

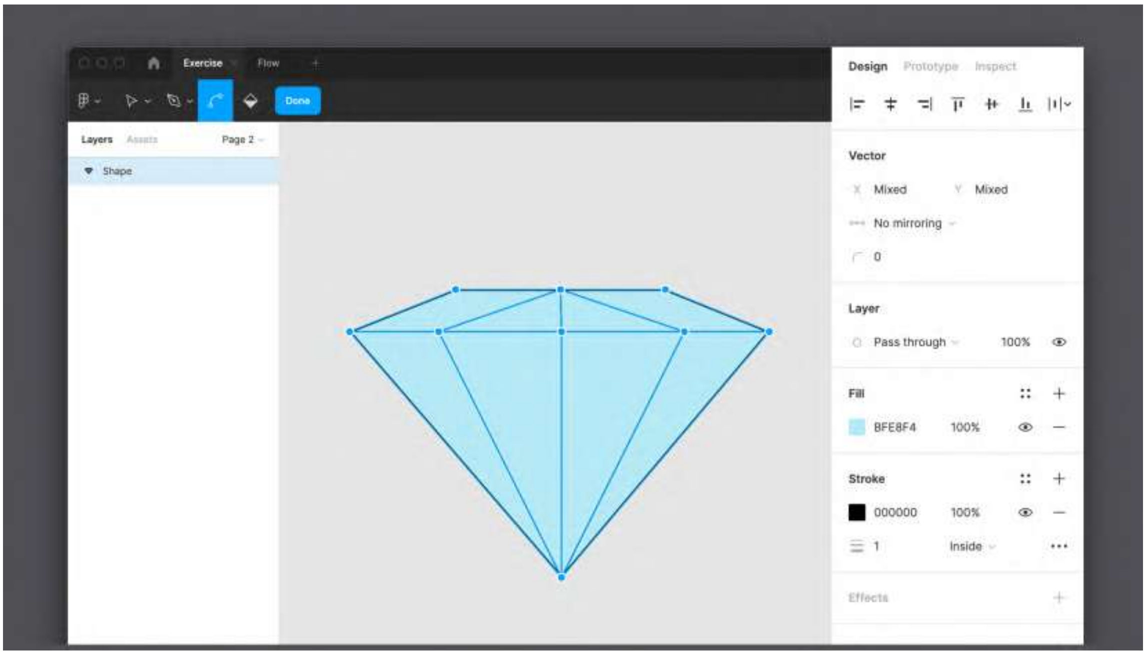

Figure 4.13 – A vector network example

If you've never worked with vectors before, this feature will come as behavior you would expect from the **Pen** tool, feeling like second nature. Otherwise, it will take some practice for those who are switching from other applications, but exploring the vector networks will open up unique opportunities for you.

However, with incredible opportunities, you can also face some difficulties. The complex shape that you create in one single vector path can be difficult to color, but there is still a way to do it in a simple and quick way. Activate edit mode by selecting the shape and pressing *Enter*, and now you can add more points and lines inside the shape to divide it into separate areas. To apply color to individual sections of your shape, you will need to use the new **Paint Bucket** tool on the top toolbar in **Pen** tool mode.

After selecting the **Paint Bucket** tool (*B*), and then hovering and moving your mouse over the shape, you will notice that various separate parts are highlighted. By clicking on the different sections, you can turn the fill color of that particular area on or off. In a recent update, Figma made it possible to use different colors for different sections of the same vector shape.

Before moving on, try creating different shapes yourself and then editing them. This practice is especially important if you are new to using these tools. The **Pen** tool and, in particular, Bézier curves may seem difficult to master at first, but with a lot of practice, you can draw all sorts of complex shapes. Keep in mind that a well-made vector shape has a minimal number of points, so it is lightweight and easy to edit. To better understand and practice these concepts, you can visit `https://bezier.method.ac` for a simple and fun game to help you master the **Pen** tool one level at a time.

Well, you've just learned a lot of essential tools that will form the foundation of your work in Figma. There will be many more complex features to explore later in the book, but knowing the basics is the first and most important step in mastering Figma. You could even say that this was the first milestone that you successfully passed! And now, let's finally see how to create an application wireframe.

Developing the app structure

Now that you have learned about the basic tools for creating graphical elements in Figma, you are ready to summarize and put into practice all this knowledge when creating a wireframe! However, if you need to practice more with shapes and vectors before continuing, it's best to allow yourself time to experiment a little with these tools until you feel more confident. When you're ready to move on, you can return to this section and continue practicing even more but, this time, with something directly related to our application. We will start by learning how to create a skeleton for our streaming service and end up with our first functional wireframe.

Flow to skeleton

Do you remember the flow you built earlier (see *Chapter 2*, *Structuring Moodboards, Personas, and User Flows within FigJam*) in FigJam? By creating it, you defined the potential future structure of the application. However, the flow is something quite abstract, and it was mainly useful for understanding the project, while the wireframe is a primitive version of the product with its navigation elements indicated. So, it's time to brush up on the flow and use it as the basis for building your wireframe.

Let's start with a new blank file and define the screen resolution as a starting point. Since our hypothetical stakeholders are interested in using the mobile version of the application, this will be the mobile interface. First, you need to transform the flow into frames, so let's add them to the canvas. Use the **Frame** tool from the top toolbar (or press the *A* or *F* key on your keyboard) and select a preset from the **Phone** category to set the container to the appropriate size. We'll use **iPhone 11 Pro / X**, but this doesn't mean that our interface won't fit an Android device, since, at this stage, we're just selecting a common screen size as a reference.

Obviously, this time, you will need more than one single frame in the working area. It's important to know that the more frames you have, the more difficult it is to recognize them and to work with layers if you don't give them unique and meaningful names. You can rename a frame by simply double-clicking the label at the top of the frame itself, or, which also works for any other element, double-clicking the name of the frame you want to rename in the **Layer** panel:

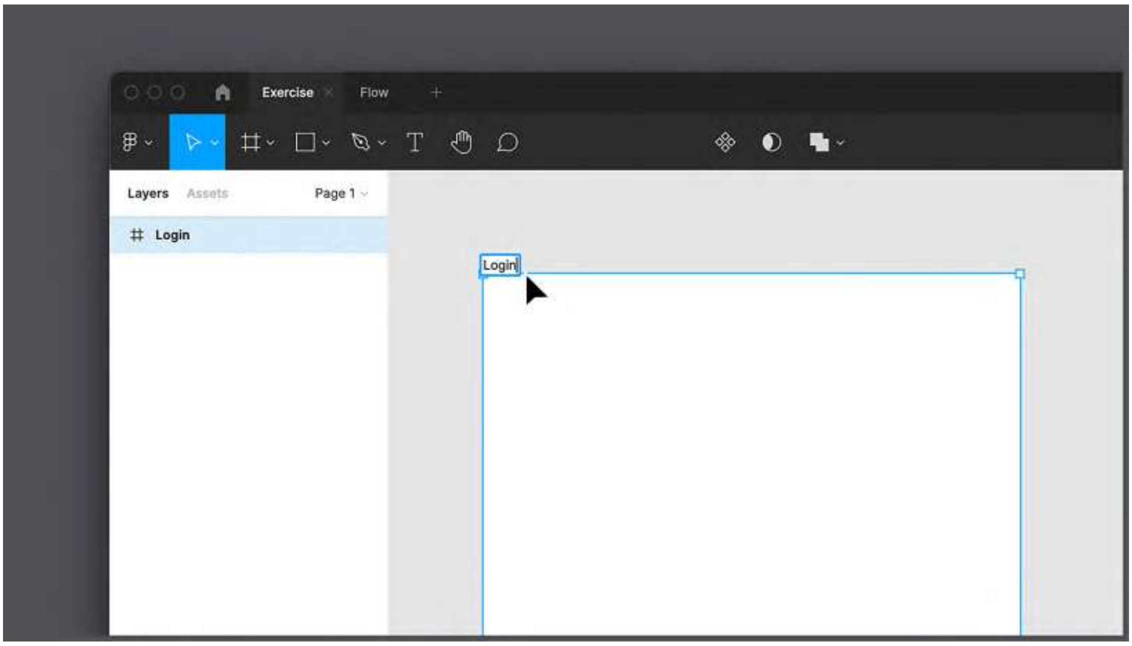

Figure 4.14 – Renaming a frame

According to the flow, after launching the application for the first time, the user sees the login page, so it makes sense to use `Login` as the name of the first frame. After this frame has been renamed, it's time to add the rest. You can do this again with the **Frame** tool, but it's much faster to just click and drag an existing frame while holding the *Option* key (macOS) or *Alt* (Windows). Then, you can add two more frames this way, or duplicate the last copy of the frame using the *Command* + *D* (macOS) or *Ctrl* + *D* (Windows) keyboard shortcut – this will automatically create a copy of the frame to the right of the duplicated one. Give each new frame an appropriate name, such as `Sign Up`, `Home`, and `Detail page`. Thus, you will prepare the basis for a complete wireframe.

Renaming layers can seem unnecessary, especially for drafts like this, but it's best to always keep the layers organized correctly. A convenient and well-thought-out naming system and layer hierarchy significantly increase the efficiency of teamwork, save your time, and in general, make your workflow much easier and more enjoyable. You can give the frames any names you see fit, or just copy them from the following screenshot:

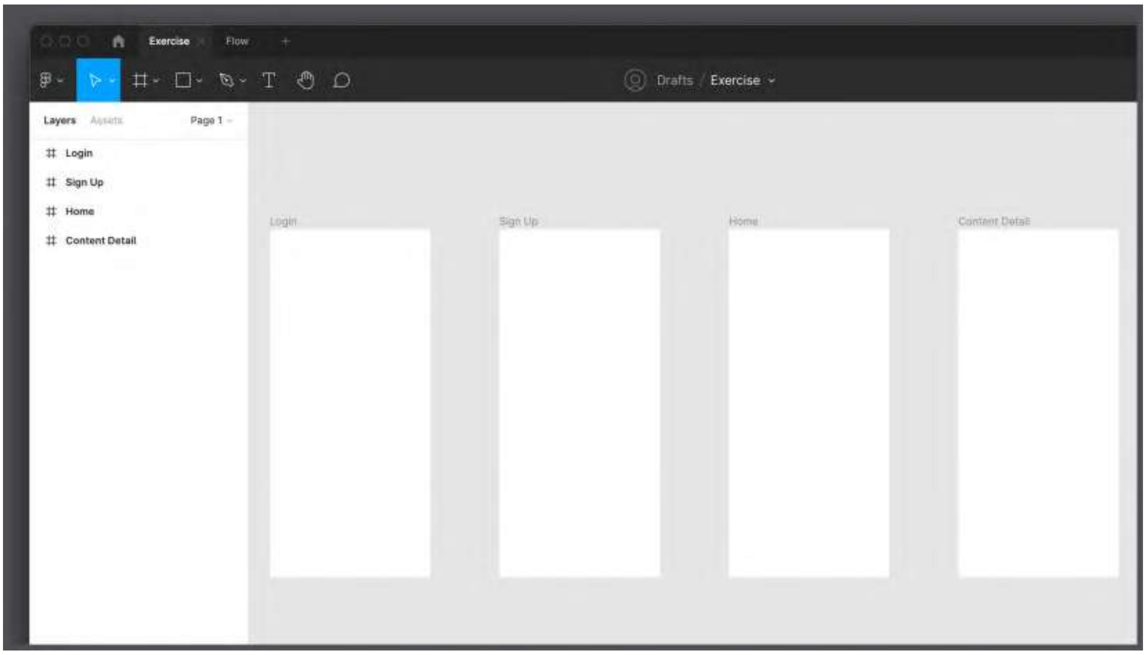

Figure 4.15 – A blank structure

Once you are done adding all the frames and renaming them, you will see that the flow is now fully displayed as the skeleton of our application. Now, you have a new challenge – to think about what elements to add to all the screens in order to set the individual view of each of them.

Shaping the interface

So, you have created a skeleton, which is a general display of all the screens of the mobile application. Now, it's time to work on each screen individually and determine what content structure they can display. There is no need to use Figma's advanced features such as constraints and auto layout to do this; you will learn about them later when working on the actual UI. For a simple wireframe, it is more than enough to use the tools you just learned about.

At this stage, as before, it's best to stick to the order of your flow, so let's start with the first view of the application, which is the **Login** page. At this point, you will need to do some research again. It's important to think through and define the elements that typically make up the page you create to make sure that nothing is overlooked. So, what elements must the **Login** page contain? No doubt, it must include username and password text fields, a confirmation button, a password recovery function, and a link to the **Sign Up** page if your user doesn't have an account yet.

Now that you have a list of all the screen elements you need, all you have to do is place each one in the **Login** frame, leaving enough room for text fields, buttons, and other elements. Let's get started:

1. Select the **Rectangle** tool (*R*) and draw a 315 x 50 rectangular shape (while drawing the shape, you can check its size in real time underneath it). It is important to know that if a shape or any other object is originally drawn in the frame, it will be placed directly inside it. Try creating another shape temporarily out of frame, and you'll see that the two shapes are positioned differently in the **Layers** panel.

2. If you select a rectangle within the frame, you can see its dimensions (**W** = width and **H** = height) and its position (**X** = horizontal and **Y** = vertical) in the **Design** panel on the right. Since this shape is placed inside the login frame, its positioning values will be relative to the outer container, starting at the top left corner. Place the rectangle at **30** on the **X** axis and **272** on the **Y** axis. You can modify these values visually by moving the rectangle with the mouse or directly by manually changing the numerical values in the right panel:

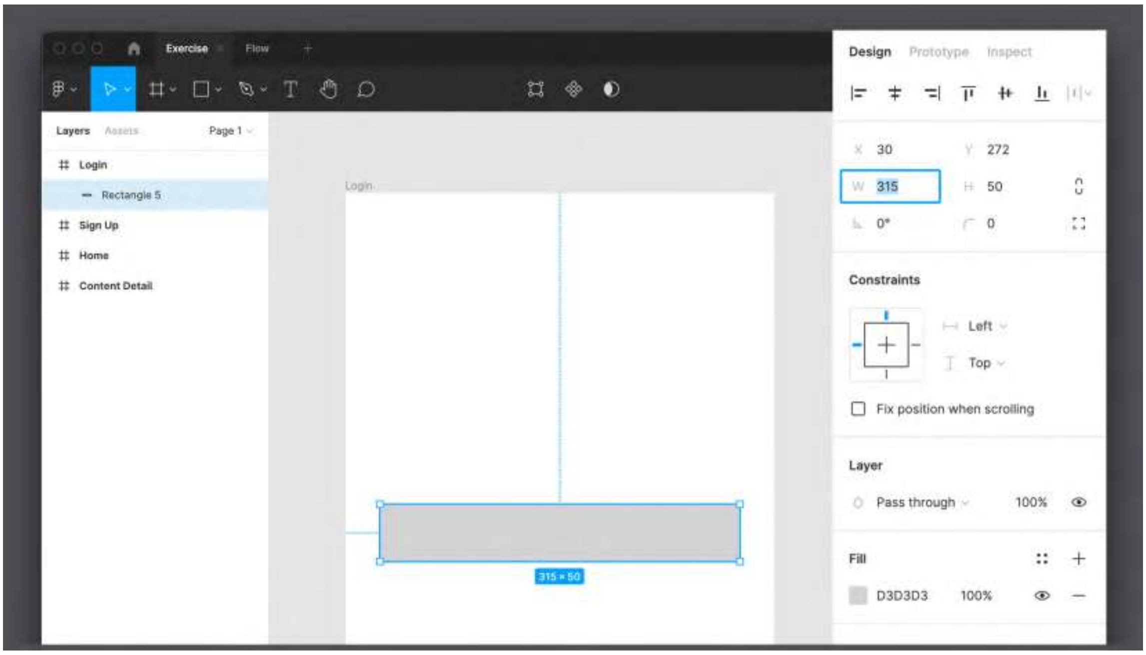

Figure 4.16 – Positioning a shape

3. In the **Fill** section of the **Design** panel, click the color code and write `lightgray` (no spaces) or, if you prefer, enter the hex code `D3D3D3`. You will learn more about colors in the next chapter.

4. Then, select the **Text** tool (*T*) and click just above the upper left corner of the rectangle. Enter `Username`. Make sure it is well aligned to the left. If you select the text and drag it, Figma will show you contextual guides to help you align that element with others nearby. Once this is done, your first text field with a corresponding indicative label is ready.
5. Next, select the label (text) and text field (rectangle) together and duplicate everything as you did before by clicking and dragging the elements while holding the *Option* key (macOS) or *Alt* (Windows), or using the *Command* + *C* (macOS) or *Ctrl* + *C* (Windows) classic keyboard shortcut to copy and *Command* + *C* (macOS) or *Ctrl* + *C* (Windows) to paste. In this case, you need to move the duplicated elements down by about 100 px:

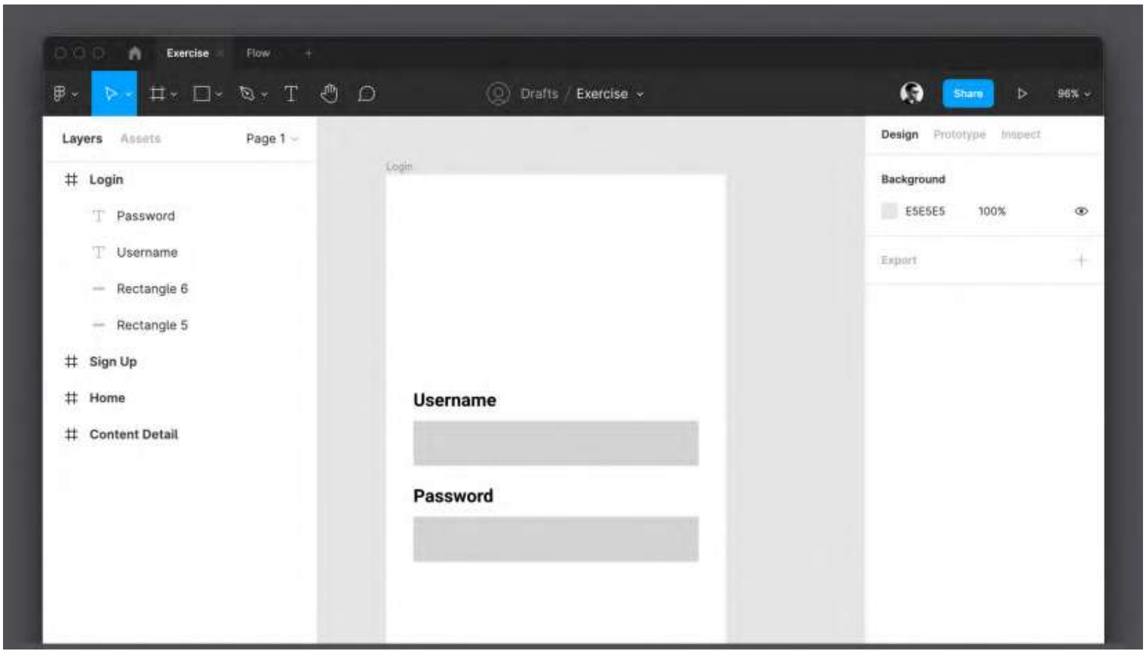

Figure 4.17 – The Username and Password text fields

6. The rectangle you just duplicated will be the **Password** field. Therefore, change the duplicated label text from `Login` to `Password` by double-clicking it to enter edit mode.

7. Now, select the **Rectangle** tool (*R*) again and draw a 315 x 75 shape below the two fields. This time, it will be a confirmation button to confirm the user's login, so let's place it about 200 px below the password field. To make the button more accented, since this is a key action, let's give it a `lightgreen` color:

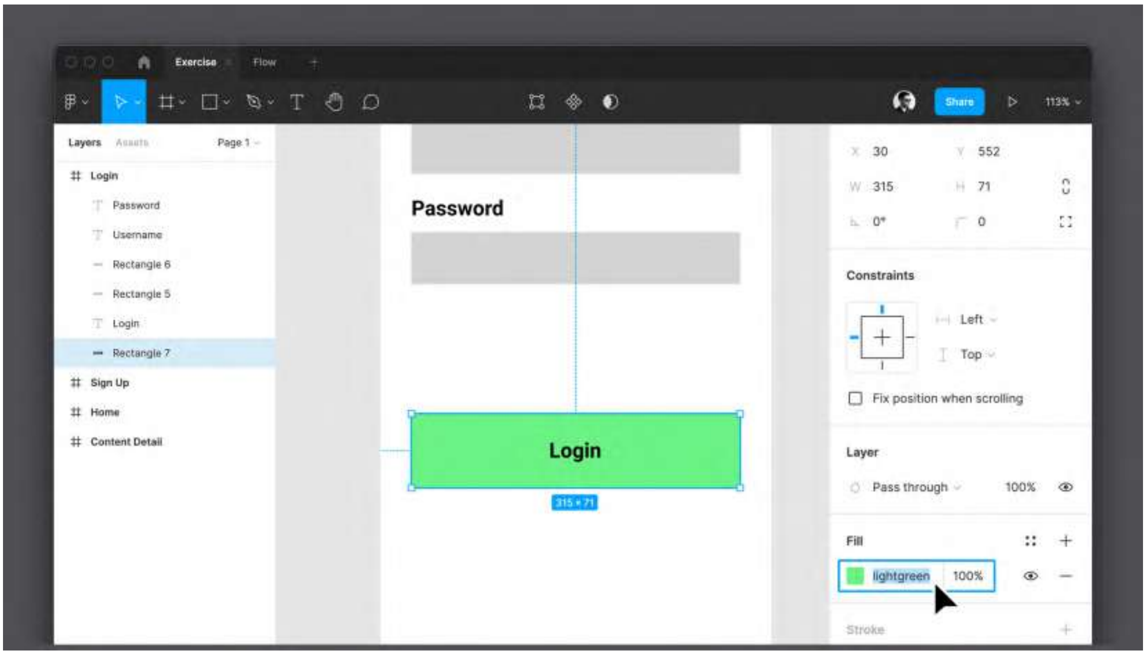

Figure 4.18 – Changing the background color

8. A button cannot be fully identified until it has a label on it. So, let's select the **Text** tool (*T*) again and click inside your button. Enter `Login` to mark the action for the element. Try to position the label exactly in the center of the button using the mouse and sensitive guides.

9. The last elements you need to add are the **Sign Up** button (it's a secondary button, so it will not be highlighted) and a link to restore the user's password right under the password text field. Before moving on, look at the **Layers** panel, and you will see that your layers are getting messy. It would be bad practice to leave it this way, so before you continue, dedicate 5 minutes to renaming each layer so that they can be easily identified:

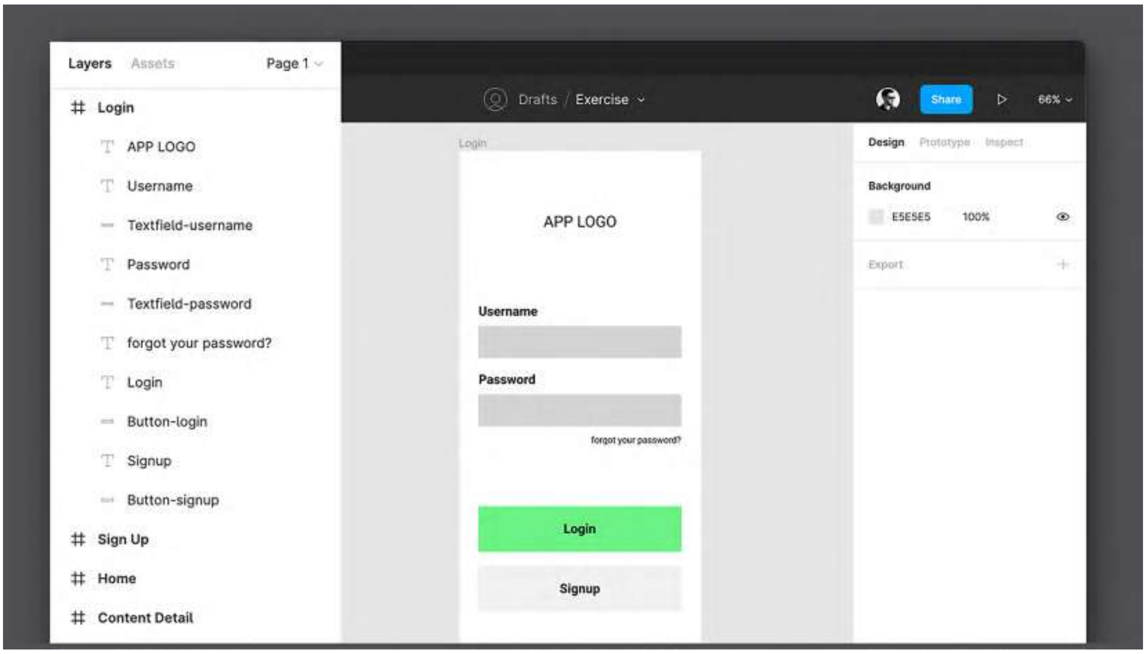

Figure 4.19 – The polished wireframe of the Login view

To organize your layers even better, you can group the username label with its text field by selecting them together and pressing *Command* + *G* (macOS) or *Ctrl* + *G* (Windows) on your keyboard. Try to group the password label and its text field in the same way and each button shape with its respective text label, and then give these new groups proper recognizable names in the **Layers** panel.

Great! You have completed your first screen view! Now, you need to fill the rest of the application screens with the necessary elements using the same methodology:

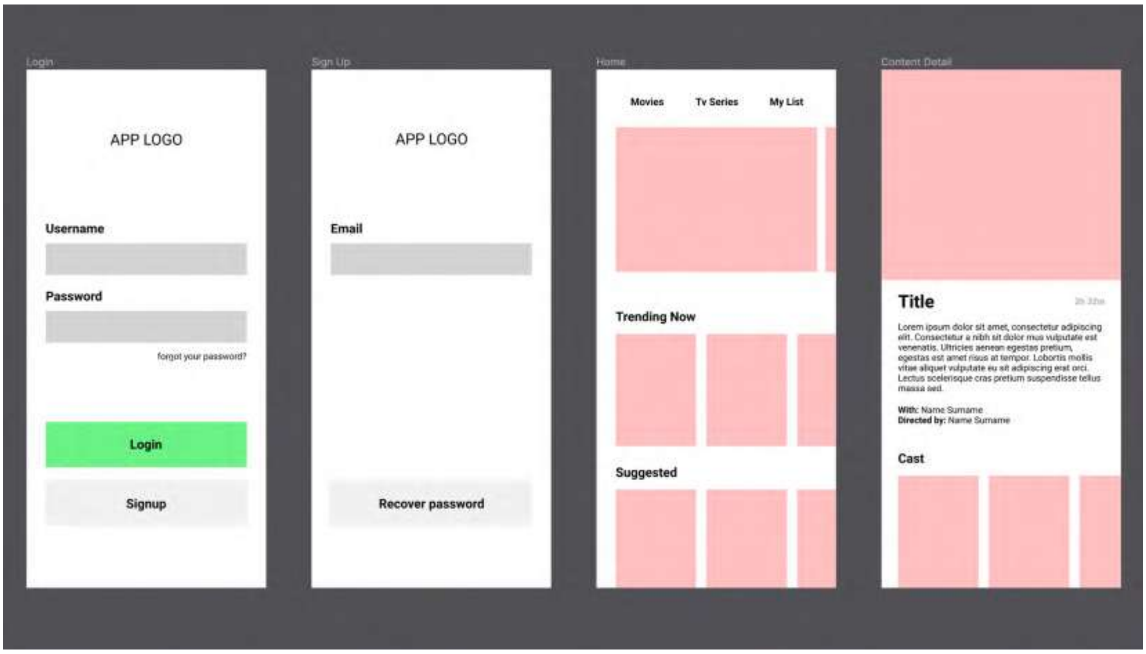

Figure 4.20 – The finished wireframe structure

You can see that once you are done with the wireframe, the structure of any application or website that you might be working on in the future becomes much clearer. After this step, the next one is to test the flow by sending your wireframe to users in your target audience. Remember that with a well-made, tested, and approved framework, further design steps will be much more deliberate and enjoyable.

What's next?

As you can see, this chapter was full of all sorts of new information for you, but if you have reached this point, you can be proud of yourself. Now, you've got an idea of what a wireframe is and why it's worth spending enough time on it. However, the real purpose of the wireframe isn't just filling the screen-sized frames with shapes that represent your future components. The essential meaning of this part is to make sure the flow you came up with during the UX design phase is the best one for your user. There is only one way to find out – to test this flow on a group of people belonging to the reference target. To do this, you have to make your wireframe live by prototyping it so that you can show and test the dynamic flow during user testing sessions.

The testing process is very important and must be taken very seriously; otherwise, you risk missing structural or usability issues. So, you should be prepared to review and modify your user flow and then the wireframe according to the test results, which will take more time, but it will still be much better than starting the implementation of the final product with uncertainty or doubt.

Since you are not yet familiar with Figma's prototyping function and the principles of user testing, we will keep our framework static. But when your journey of learning Figma is complete, you can come back to this chapter and build a prototype with this wireframe and then test it if you like. This would be great practice before you start doing it in your actual future design projects.

Summary

If you had any doubts about the importance of the UX part of your design workflow before, this chapter has hopefully cleared them up. Once you've identified the optimal user flow, it's pretty easy to build a wireframe based on it, although it may well happen that you need to spend more time researching which elements to use and how to place them on screens, especially if you don't have a lot of design experience. Of course, it takes time to learn about the different types of buttons, menus, bars, and other components, but with experience, you will have no problem figuring out which elements are suitable to include on a particular screen. You can also help yourself by paying more attention to the details of your favorite apps in daily use as well as discovering new ones.

So, this chapter was your first milestone in learning how to create a user interface in Figma. You learned and tried out many new tools, and then used them to create the first wireframe of our application, which was a great way to put your fresh knowledge into practice! It's twice as helpful if you haven't just followed the practical instructions in this chapter but have also worked on your own, as it will speed up your learning curve in Figma!

In the next chapter, you'll discover a whole new pack of amazing tools in Figma, specifically how to work with images, text, colors, grids, styles, and more!